

The Symposium
and
The Phaedrus

Plato's Erotic Dialogues

Translated with Introduction
and Commentaries by

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The Phaedrus

INTRODUCTION

The *Phaedrus* presents a complex conversation between Socrates and Phaedrus, a younger man who is also a key figure in the *Symposium*. The dialogue contains three speeches, one ostensibly by the famous rhetorician Lysias, which is read by Phaedrus, and two invented by Socrates for the occasion. Lysias' speech and the first by Socrates are in praise of the advantages of establishing a liaison with a nonlover rather than a lover.¹ Socrates' second speech praises the merits of a lover. After the three speeches are presented, there is a lengthy discussion of the art of making speeches. The *Phaedrus* is usually included among the middle-period dialogues, though whether it was composed before or after the *Symposium* cannot be determined with any certainty.²

The dialogue situates the conversation as occurring around 410–405 B.C.E.³ Socrates is depicted as an older man, and Phaedrus as younger, but not a youth. The Athenian orator Lysias, whose speech plays a large role in the dialogue, had a high reputation in the ancient world. Several of his speeches are extant. Whether the speech attributed to him in the *Phaedrus* was actually from his hand or written by Plato in Lysias' style is a subject of some controversy.⁴ The dialogue refers to many other prominent figures in ancient Athens. Especially striking is the reference at the end of the dialogue (278e) to Isocrates, a contemporary of Plato who was a famous teacher of rhetoric and a strong critic of Plato and Socrates as impractical visionaries. There are also a large number of references to the gods in the *Phaedrus*, and several myths are told.

In a special way, this dialogue presupposes a distinctive feature of ancient Athenian society, namely, the prominence of the teaching and practice of rhetoric. As any reader of Plato's *Apology* knows, Athenian justice was decided by large juries. The one Socrates faced contained 500 members. Moreover, the assembly of the citizens had a great deal of power and often served as the ultimate authority in the community. In such a society, the abil-

ity to speak persuasively was the key to personal prominence and political success, and teachers of this skill were highly regarded and richly rewarded. A number of these teachers and the things they taught are discussed in this dialogue.

The overall structure of the *Phaedrus* is fairly simple: Socrates and Phaedrus meet and decide to go to a quiet place outside of town to read a speech by Lysias. In response to Lysias' speech Socrates gives two speeches of his own. He and Phaedrus then engage in an extended discussion of the art of making speeches. A simple outline would be:

1. Introduction: 227a–230e
2. The Speeches about Love: 230e–257b
 - A. Lysias' speech: 230e–234c
 - B. Socrates' first speech: 237a–241a
 - C. Socrates' second speech: 243e–257b
3. The Art of Making Speeches: 257b–278b
4. Conclusion: 278b–279c

THE DIALOGUE

SOCRATES: My friend *Phaedrus*! Where are you going and where have you come from? 227a

PHAEDRUS: From *Lysias*,⁵ the son of *Cephalus*, *Socrates*, and I'm going for a walk outside the walls because I sat there for a long time, from early morning, in fact. And since I obey that associate of yours and mine, *Acumenus*,⁶ I take walks along the country roads, for he says they are less exhausting than laps around the exercise tracks. 227b

S: Well, he's right in saying so, my friend. So it seems *Lysias* was in town, then.

P: Yes, at *Epicrates*' place, the house that used to be *Morychus*'s, near the temple of *Olympian Zeus*.⁷

S: How did you spend the time? Or is it obvious that *Lysias* was entertaining you with a feast of his speeches?

P: You shall hear, if you have the leisure to come along and listen.

S: What! Don't you think that I'd make hearing how you and *Lysias* passed the time something that, as *Pindar* says, "is even more important than business?"⁸

P: Lead on, then. 227c

S: Please speak.

P: Actually, *Socrates*, it's appropriate that you should hear it because the speech with which we were passing the time was, well, erotic, in a way.⁹ *Lysias* has actually written out an attempted seduction of a handsome boy—but not by a lover! That's what's so impressive! He says that one should gratify¹⁰ the one who does not love rather than the one who does.¹¹

S: Ah, the noble fellow! If only he would write that one should gratify a poor man rather than a rich one, and an older man rather than a younger one, and so on for the many other things that are characteristic of me and of most of us. Then his speeches would indeed be urbane and beneficial to the general public. Of course, I'm so eager to hear it that if you walk as far as *Megara*¹² on your stroll, I won't be left behind by you, even if you come right back after you reach the wall, as *Herodicus*¹³ recommends. 227d

P: My dear *Socrates*! What are you saying? Do you expect an amateur like me to recite from memory, and without disgracing *Lysias*, what that cleverest of current writers composed at leisure over a long period of time? That's way beyond me, although I'd rather be able to do that than come into a large fortune. 228a

S: Oh, Phaedrus! If I don't know Phaedrus, I have forgotten myself, yet neither of these things is true. I know very well that, while listening to Lysias' speech, this fellow didn't hear it only once, but urged Lysias to speak and repeat it many times, and Lysias was gladly persuaded to do so. However, this wasn't enough for him, and finally, seizing the manuscript, he went over the parts that he liked best. After sitting and doing this since early morning, he grew tired and went for a walk, as I suspect, by the dog,¹⁴ knowing the speech by heart, unless it was very long. He was setting out on a walk outside the walls to practice it. Then, when he met someone who is obsessive about listening to speeches, he was delighted to see him because now he would have someone with whom to share his Corybantic revels,¹⁵ and he urged him to lead the way. When the lover of speeches begged him to speak, he became coy, pretending he didn't want to speak, though he intended to do so in the end, even if he had to force himself upon an unwilling audience. So, Phaedrus, require him to do right now what he'll soon be doing in any case.¹⁶

P: By far the best thing for me, surely, is to speak in whatever way I can, since you don't seem at all likely to let me go until I speak somehow or other.

S: Well, your surmise about me is quite true.

P: Then this is what I'll do. Actually, Socrates, I didn't really learn his exact words by heart, but I'll go through the general sense of all his points about how the one who loves differs from the one who does not, going through them in order beginning with the first.

S: After you first show, dear friend, what you're holding in your left hand under your cloak! I suspect you have the speech itself. If that's so, believe this of me, that though I am of course your friend, if Lysias himself is here, I have no intention of making myself available for you to practice on. Come on, show it.

P: Stop! You've dashed my hope of using you for a rehearsal, Socrates, but where do you want us to sit while we read?

S: Let's turn aside here and go along the Ilissus; then we can sit down in a quiet spot wherever you like.

P: It's fortunate, it seems, that I happen to be barefooted; you, of course, always are.¹⁷ So, it will be easiest for us to wade in the stream getting our feet wet, which won't be unpleasant, especially at this hour at this time of year.

S: Then lead on, and look for a place where we can sit down.

P: Well then, do you see that very tall plane-tree?¹⁸

S: What about it?

P: There's shade there and a moderate breeze, and grass to sit on or, if we'd like, to lie down on. 229b

S: Please lead the way.

P: Tell me, Socrates, isn't it from somewhere along here on the Ilissus that Boreas is said to have abducted Oreithuia?¹⁹

S: So they say.

P: Was it from right here? The water certainly seems delightfully pure and sparkling, a suitable spot for young girls to play.

S: No, the place is some two or three hundred yards farther along, where we cross over to the district of Agra.²⁰ There's an altar to Boreas²¹ at the spot. 229c

P: I haven't really noticed. But tell me, Socrates, before Zeus, do you believe this mythical tale to be true?

S: If I disbelieved it, as the wise do, I wouldn't be odd.²² In that case, being wise, I might say that while she was playing with Pharmaceia²³ a puff of wind²⁴ pushed her off the nearby rocks, and that when she came to her end in this manner she was said to have been carried off by Boreas. Or else it was from the Areopagus,²⁵ for the story is also told that she was abducted from there rather than from here. I myself, Phaedrus, believe that such things, while amusing, are the work of a man who is exceedingly clever and industrious but not at all fortunate for no other reason than that after this he must account for the form of the Centaurs and then for that of the Chimaera, and then a crowd of such creatures floods in upon him, Gorgons and Pegasuses and a great number of other inexplicable and odd creatures of which strange things are said.²⁶ If someone who disbelieves in these things is to bring forth a plausible account of each of them, using a sort of rustic ingenuity, he'll need a great deal of leisure. I myself have no leisure at all for such business, and the reason for that, my friend, is this: I'm not yet able, in accordance with the Delphic²⁷ inscription, to know myself, and it seems ridiculous to me to investigate things that don't concern me while still lacking that knowledge. So, I leave those matters alone, and being persuaded by what is traditionally maintained about them, I investigate (as I was saying just now) not those things but myself, as to whether I happen to be a beast more complex and agitated than Typhon,²⁸ or a gentler and simpler animal, possessing by nature a divine and un-Typhonic lot. 229d 229e 230a

But, my friend, in the midst of our conversation, isn't this the tree that you were leading us to?

P: That's so; this is it. 230b

S: By Hera,²⁹ it is a beautiful resting place! This plane-tree is very wide-spreading and tall. The height and thick shade of the chaste tree³⁰ are also

splendid, and since it's in full bloom, it will make the place very fragrant. Moreover, the spring flowing from under the plane-tree is very pleasant, with quite cold water, to judge by my foot. From the figurines and statues it seems to be a place sacred to some of the Nymphs and Achelous.³¹ Furthermore, if you please, the fresh breezes of the place are lovely and exceedingly sweet, reverberating with the shrill summer chorus of the cicadas. However, the most exquisite thing of all is this grassy slope whose gentle rise makes a quite comfortable and natural place to rest one's head while lying down. You are an excellent guide for the visiting stranger, Phaedrus my friend! 230c

P: And you, you surprising man, appear to be the oddest person. You really seem to be a visiting stranger being guided around, as you say, and not a native. You seem to me to be acting as though you never go out across the frontier and in fact as though you don't even go outside the city walls! 230d

S: Forgive me, you most excellent fellow, for I'm a friend of learning. The countryside and the trees don't want to teach me anything, but the people in town do. Yet you seem to me to have found the prescription³² to bring me out. Just as people lead hungry animals by shaking a branch or some fruit in front of them, it appears that by holding manuscripts of speeches out in front of me you can lead me all around Attica and anywhere else you wish. Now that we've arrived at this place, I intend to lie down, and you, when you've taken whatever position you think easiest for reading, read. 230e

P: Listen, then.

You understand my situation, and you have heard how I think it would be to our advantage for this to happen. Because I am not your lover, I deserve not to be disappointed in what I request. When lovers' desires cease, they regret their earlier generosity, but for nonlovers there never comes a time when they find it appropriate to change their minds. Nonlovers are as generous as they can be, not out of compulsion, but willingly, for they make their plans in terms of what is in their own best interest. 231a

Furthermore, when those who love consider their earlier generosity and the way their own interests have been managed badly because of their love, and when they also take into account the trouble they have had, they believe that they long ago repaid those they love for their kindness. But those who do not love cannot make this excuse of neglect of their own interests because of their condition, nor count up past troubles, nor make accusations about quarrels with their relatives. Hence, since these evils are removed, nothing remains for those who do not love but to do eagerly whatever they think will gratify the recipients of their attention. 231b

Furthermore, if lovers are highly regarded because they say they are the greatest of friends to those they love and that they are prepared to be hated by 231c

others for their words and their deeds in order to please those they love, it is easy to see, if they are telling the truth, that those whom they fall in love with later will matter more to them than their earlier loves; and it is clear that, if their later loves suggest it, they will treat the earlier ones badly.

Moreover, how reasonable is it to trust such a matter to someone who has an affliction that no experienced person would even attempt to cure? They themselves agree that they are more mad than sane and that they know their intentions are wrong but cannot control themselves. So, how could they believe, when they return to their senses, that the decisions they made in that condition were well taken? 231d

In fact, if you choose the best of your lovers, the best will be from a small group, but if you choose the one most suitable to yourself from among the others, it will be from a large group. There is a much greater hope of there being someone worthy of your friendship in the large group. 231e

Now, if prevailing convention makes you fear that you will be criticized if people find out, consider that lovers, since they believe others take them to be as worthy of emulation as they themselves do, are likely to get carried away in telling stories and will boastfully³³ proclaim to everyone that their efforts have not been in vain, but those who do not love are in control of themselves and will choose what is best rather than a public reputation. 232a

Furthermore, many people will inevitably see and hear about lovers following those they love around and making this their business, so that whenever they are seen talking to each other, people will assume that they are together because their desire either has been or is about to be satisfied. However, no one even tries to criticize nonlovers for being together, since they know that one may have to talk with someone because of friendship or for some other pleasant purpose. 232b

In fact, if you are afraid because you believe that it is difficult to hold a friendship together and that, while in other circumstances a quarrel would be a misfortune shared in common by both sides, when you have given away what you value most a quarrel would come as a great loss to yourself, then it would be reasonable for you to fear lovers more. Many things upset them, and they think that everything that happens is done to injure them. That is why they prevent those they love from associating with others, for they fear those with property, lest they surpass them in wealth, and those who are educated, lest they be superior in intellect. And they are on their guard against anyone who has acquired any other advantages. Then, if they persuade you to incur the hatred of these men, they leave you without any friends. On the other hand, if you are more sensible than they and consider your own interests, you will find that you have aroused their animosity. However, those who happened not to love, but have obtained what they want through merit, would not be jealous of those associating with you, but would detest those who do not want to do so, believing you are not appreciated by the latter, but are benefit- 232c 232d

ted by associations with the former. Thus, there is a much greater hope that friendship rather than animosity will come to you from the affair. 232e

In fact, many lovers will desire your body before they know your character or become acquainted with your circumstances, so that it is unclear to them whether they will still want to be friends after their desire ceases. But in the case of those who are not lovers, who were friends with each other before they did these things, their friendship is not likely to be diminished by the things they are fortunate enough to receive from the affair; on the contrary, such things remain as memorials of what is to come. 233a

In fact, it will be better for you to be under my influence rather than that of a lover. They commend whatever you say and do, even when it is less than the best, partly because they fear incurring your animosity and partly because their judgment is impaired by their desire. For this is how love manifests itself: it makes those who are unsuccessful treat as grievances things that do not cause distress in others, and it compels those who are successful to commend things that ought not even to be considered pleasant. So, rather than emulating them, those they love really ought to pity them. If you accept my proposal, my primary concern in associating with you will not be present pleasure, but future benefit, since I am not the slave of love but my own master. I will not be provoked to violent hostility over trivial matters; on the contrary, major problems will make me only a little angry, and that slowly. I will forgive unintentional slights and try to prevent intentional ones. Such things guarantee that a friendship will last a long time. 233b
233c

If it has been put to you that friendship cannot be significant unless one happens to be in love, you must consider that in that case our sons would not be very important to us, nor our fathers and mothers, nor would we have faithful friends who have not been acquired through that sort of desire but on the basis of other concerns. 233d

Furthermore, if one ought to gratify those who are most in need, then it would be appropriate for you to be generous, not to the best people, but to the most needy, for they will be most grateful since they have been relieved of the greatest sufferings. In fact, it would also be appropriate for you to invite to private parties, not your friends, but beggars in need of a meal, for they will adore you, follow you around, and hang around your front door. They will be most delighted and grateful and will pray that you receive many blessings. Perhaps, however, it is appropriate to gratify, not those with the greatest need, but rather those who are best able to return the kindness; not those who are merely in love with you, but rather those who are worthy of the affair; not those who will enjoy your youthful good looks, but rather those who will share their possessions with you when you are older; not those who, when they have been successful, will boast of it to everyone,³⁴ but rather those who out of modesty will tell no one; not those who court you zealously for a short time, but rather those who will be steadfast friends throughout their entire life; 233e
234a

and not those who, when their desire ceases, will look for some excuse for breaking up with you, but rather those who will display their own excellence when your youthful good looks have passed.

234b

So, remember what has been said and bear in mind that their friends admonish lovers for engaging in bad behavior, but not even a relative has ever admonished those who do not love for making bad decisions about their own interests on that account.

Perhaps you will ask me, then, if I am advising you to gratify everyone who does not love you. I do not believe that a lover would urge you to think that way about everyone who loves you. Your kindness would not be so much appreciated by the recipient in that case, nor would you be able to hide your relationship with the one from the others, if you should wish to do so. No harm at all should come from this sort of affair; it should benefit both parties.

234c

So, I think that what has been said is sufficient, but if you believe that anything has been omitted, and want more, just ask.

P: What do you think of the speech, Socrates? Isn't it superb, both in terms of its language and in other respects?

S: It does have an unearthly³⁵ power, my friend, so that I was astounded by it. I felt that way because of you, Phaedrus. As I looked at you, you seemed to me to be set aglow by the speech as you read. Since I believe you understand such things better than I do, I followed your lead and joined your divinely inspired self in Bacchanalian ecstasy.³⁶

234d

P: What! Does it seem a joking matter?

S: Why, do you think I'm being playful rather than serious?

P: Not at all, Socrates; but tell me truly, before Zeus the god of friendship, do you think that anyone else among the Greeks could speak more ably or fully on the same subject?

234e

S: What's this? Should you and I praise the speech as one in which the author has said what he ought to have, rather than merely because each of his expressions has been precisely crafted in a clear and well-turned manner? If we should, we must agree to do so on for your authority since, on account of my negligence, that aspect of it escaped my notice. I paid attention to it only as an example of rhetoric, and in that regard I would think that Lysias himself wouldn't consider it satisfactory. In fact, it seemed to me, Phaedrus, unless you disagree, that he repeated the same things two or three times, as though he didn't find it very easy to say much about the subject or perhaps wasn't really interested in it. Indeed, he appeared to me to be indulging in youthful extravagance, showing off his ability to say the same thing in two different ways, both stated in the best possible manner.

235a

P: You're talking nonsense, Socrates. That's the greatest thing about the

235b

speech: it omits nothing that ought to be said about the subject, so that no one could ever speak on this topic in a more complete or more admirable way.

S: You won't persuade me of that. If I should agree, just to please you, wise men and women who have spoken and written about these matters in the past will refute me.

P: Who are these people? Where have you heard something better than this? 235c

S: I can't say just now, but I'm sure I've heard better from someone, perhaps from the beautiful Sappho or the wise Anacreon³⁷ or even from some prose writers. On what grounds do I say this? Somehow, you divine fellow, the fullness of my heart makes me feel I could say some things about this subject that would be different and not inferior. Now, I am well aware that I've not thought them up by myself; I know my own ignorance. So, I assume they're the remains of others' efforts that poured in while I was listening and filled me up like a jug, but through stupidity I've forgotten where and from whom I heard them. 235d

P: An excellent proposal, most noble Socrates! Don't tell me, even if I demand it, where or from whom you heard these things, but just do what you're suggesting. You've promised that you'll offer different points than those in the manuscript that are better and no fewer in number; and I promise you that, for my part, like the nine Archons, I'll put up a golden, life-sized statue in Delphi, not only of myself, but of you also. 235e

S: You are a dear friend and truly golden, Phaedrus, if you think I'm saying that Lysias has completely missed the mark and that I could say something entirely different from what he says. I don't think that could happen even with the poorest writer. For example, regarding the subject of his speech, do you suppose that anyone could argue that one should gratify the one who does not love rather than the one who does and omit praise of the good sense of the one and condemnation of the foolishness of the other, which are inevitable points, and say something different instead? I think such points must be allowed and the speaker be forgiven for using them. Of such things, we should praise not the invention, but the presentation. In the case of points that are not inevitable, and are difficult to invent, we should praise both their presentation and their invention. 236a

P: I agree with what you're saying. Your point seems reasonable; so this is what I'll do. I'll allow you to use the assumption that the lover is more mad than the nonlover, but for the rest, when you state a greater number of points than those of Lysias, that are different and better than his, your statue shall stand beside the offering of the Cypselids at Olympia.³⁸ 236b

S: Have you taken me seriously, Phaedrus, because in order to tease you I

attacked your darling?³⁹ Do you really think I'm actually going to attempt to say something different and of greater ingenuity, than the output of his wisdom?

P: As to that, my friend, I've got you in the bind you had me in earlier. You certainly must speak as best you can, lest we be compelled to perform the tedious role of comedians engaging in repartee. Be careful, and don't deliberately force me to say, "Socrates, if I don't know Socrates, I have forgotten myself," or "he wanted to speak but he became coy." Instead, take note that we're not going to leave this spot until you state what you said was filling your heart. We're alone in this isolated place, and I'm stronger and younger. Given all these circumstances, "hark what I am saying"⁴⁰ and don't choose to speak under duress when you could speak voluntarily. 236c 236d

S: But, Phaedrus, you lucky fellow, I'll be a laughingstock if I, an amateur, improvise on the same subject in competition with an accomplished author.

P: You know the situation. Stop putting on airs. I can say something that will very nearly compel you to speak.

S: Then you shouldn't say it.

P: I shouldn't, but I shall; and my speech will be an oath. I swear to you—by what, by which god? Or do you prefer it be by this plane-tree here? Well, then, I swear that unless you deliver your speech in the presence of this very tree, I will never show you or report to you another speech by anyone, not a single one! 236e

S: Alas! You bloody wretch! What an effective means you've discovered for compelling a man who's a friend of speeches to do what you command.

P: Then why do you twist and turn so?

S: Not any more, since you've sworn that oath. How could I survive without that sort of banquet?

P: Speak then! 237a

S: Do you know what I'm going to do?

P: In what regard?

S: I'm going to speak with my head covered, so that I can rush through my speech as quickly as possible and, by not looking at you, avoid faltering through being ashamed.

P: Just speak! Do whatever you like otherwise.

S: Lead on then, clear-voiced Muses—whether you have the name clear-voiced because of the quality of your song or because of the race of Ligurians⁴¹ who are adept in the arts of the Muses. Take hold with me of the tale this

excellent fellow here forces me to tell, so that his associate, who seemed wise to him before, will now seem even more so.

237b

There once was a boy, or rather a young man, who was very handsome and had a great many lovers. One of them, a crafty fellow who loved him no less than the others, had convinced the boy that he did not love him. And on one occasion when he was courting him, he tried to convince him of this very point, that one ought to gratify the one who does not love in preference to the one who does, and he spoke as follows.

For those who intend to consider something successfully, my boy, there is only one way to begin in every case. They must know what it is they are deliberating about, or they will inevitably miss the mark entirely. Most people fail to realize that they do not know what things really are. So, since they assume they know, they do not establish mutually agreed upon definitions at the beginning of their enquiry, and as they proceed the result is what you would expect: they agree neither with themselves nor with each other. Now, let's not allow ourselves to suffer what we are condemning in others. Since the question before us is whether one should enter into a friendship with one who loves or with one who does not, let us agree on a definition of love, as to what sort of thing it is and what power it possesses, and make our enquiry as to whether it brings benefit or harm with this held in view for reference.

237c

237d

It is clear to everyone that love is some sort of desire. Moreover, we know that even those who are not lovers desire beautiful things. How then are we to distinguish the one who loves from the one who does not?

We must note that there are two sorts of ruling or guiding principles in each of us, which we follow wherever they lead. One is the innate desire for pleasure, and the other is an acquired judgment that aims at what is best. These two principles in us are sometimes in accord, and sometimes they are at variance. Sometimes one prevails and at other times the other. When judgment guides us by reason⁴² toward what is best and is strong enough to prevail, we call that judiciousness. When desire rules in us and drags us toward pleasure in a manner contrary to reason, its rule is called *hubris*.⁴³ But *hubris* has many names, for it has many parts and takes many forms, and whichever of these forms happens to dominate gives its name to the person who has what is called by that name—an acquisition without honor or merit. For example, when the desire for food prevails over rational judgment as to what is best as well as over other desires, it is called gluttony and gives the corresponding name of glutton to the person who has it. When the desire for strong drink becomes the tyrant and leads the person who possesses it toward drink, it is obvious what name he is called, and with regard to other such desires and the related names for people who have them, it is quite clear that whenever one of the desires dominates it is appropriate to be called by its name.

237e

238a

238b

The point of all that has been said up to now is already rather obvious, but

everything is probably clearer when stated than when not. The irrational desire that leads us toward the enjoyment of beauty and overpowers the judgment that directs us toward what is right, and that is victorious in leading us toward physical beauty when it is powerfully strengthened by the desires related to it, takes its name from this very strength and is called love.⁴⁴ 238c

Well, *Phaedrus*, my friend, does it seem to you, as it does to me, that I've been seized by a divinely inspired passion?

P: Certainly, *Socrates*, some sort of unusual fluency has seized you.

S: Then hear me in silence. This place really does seem divine; so if, as I present my speech, I often seem to be possessed by the *Nymphs*, don't be surprised. Already I'm close to speaking in the *dithyrambic* style.⁴⁵ 238d

P: What you say is very true.

S: It's you who are responsible for this. But hear the rest of it; perhaps what threatens can be averted, although that's a matter for a god—we must return to the boy in our speech.

Well, you most fortunate fellow, what it is that we are to deliberate about has been stated and defined. Keeping that in view, let us talk about what remains, namely, what benefit or harm is likely to come from the lover and the nonlover to the one who gratifies them. 238e

Anyone ruled by desire and enslaved by pleasure inevitably makes his beloved as delightful to himself as possible, and to someone who is sick, all lack of opposition is pleasant, while superiority or equality is offensive. So, a lover will not tolerate a darling who is superior or equal to himself, but always makes him inferior and deficient by comparison; and the ignorant is inferior to the wise, the cowardly to the brave, the incompetent speaker to the orator, the slow to the quick-witted. A lover is bound to be pleased when such intellectual defects and more besides develop or exist by nature in the one he loves, and he will try to induce more in him lest he be deprived of his immediate pleasure. In fact, a lover is inevitably jealous and causes great harm by preventing many advantageous associations with others that would greatly facilitate his beloved's growing into manhood, and the greatest harm will be caused by preventing that association which would make his beloved supremely wise. This happens to be philosophy, the divine friendship with wisdom, which a lover inevitably keeps his darling away from for fear of becoming an object of contempt. He will also contrive other ways to keep him ignorant in every regard and dependent on his lover for everything, so that the beloved will be most pleasant for his lover, but most damaging to himself. With regard to intellectual matters, then, a man who is in love is in no way a profitable guardian and companion. 239a
239b
239c

We must next consider the condition and care of the body as to how someone who is compelled to pursue pleasure in preference to good will take care of that when he becomes one's master. He will be seen to pursue someone who is soft rather than tough, who was not reared in clear sunshine but in mottled shade, who is unacquainted with manly toil and dried sweat, but accustomed to a soft, unmanly way of life, who uses artificial cosmetics to cover his lack of a natural complexion, and all the other practices that go along with these, which are obvious and not worth further enumeration. We can go on to other things after making a single statement in summation: this is the sort of body that, in war and in other important crises, inspires confidence in one's enemies and apprehension in one's friends—and even in one's lovers themselves. 239d

We may leave that as obvious, but we must talk about what's next in order, namely, what benefit or harm to us the company and guardianship of the lover will bring in regard to our possessions. It is evident to everyone, and especially to a lover, that he would pray above all that his beloved be bereft of those who are for him the most friendly, most well-intentioned, and most divine, for a lover would welcome his beloved's being deprived of father and mother, relatives and friends, since he believes they will cause difficulties and raise objections to his most delightful relationship with his beloved. Moreover, he will believe that someone who has property, whether gold or other possessions, will not be as easily caught nor, when caught, as easily managed. As a result it is altogether inevitable that a lover will be jealous of the property his darling possesses and rejoice at its loss. Furthermore, a lover would pray that his darling be without wife, children, or home as long as possible, since he wants to enjoy his beloved's sweetness all by himself for as long as possible. 239e 240a

There are also other evils, but some divine agency has added a momentary pleasure to most of them, as, for example, in the case of a sycophant, who is a terrible beast and very harmful, yet his nature nevertheless includes a certain pleasantness that is not entirely unrefined. Some would also condemn as harmful a prostitute and many other similar creatures and practices that are very pleasant at the time. A lover, however, besides being harmful to his darling, is also a most unpleasant thing to live with on a daily basis. There is an ancient saying to the effect that people who are one age enjoy those of the same age (I suppose the equality of age leads to similar tastes in pleasure and produces friendship through such similarity), yet even companions of this sort can grow tired of being together. Moreover, compulsiveness of every sort is said to be oppressive to everyone, and a lover, in addition to the dissimilarity of age, certainly has that in relation to his darling. An older man associating with a younger one will not be willingly left behind either by day or by night. He is driven by a tormenting compulsion that leads him on by giving him continual pleasure from seeing, hearing, touching, and experiencing his beloved through all his senses, so that he delights in serving all his darling's needs. 240b 240c 240d

Yet what consolation or pleasure can he give his beloved that could prevent the extended time they spend together being extremely unpleasant for the beloved? The beloved must look at a face that is old and past its prime, and other things that go along with that which it is unpleasant even to hear talked about, let alone to deal with when one is constantly compelled to confront them: being suspiciously guarded all the time against everybody; and hearing importunate and exaggerated compliments as well as criticisms that are intolerable when he is sober but when he is in his cups and indulges freely in coarse and uninhibited language, become not only intolerable but disgusting. 240e

While a lover loves he is harmful and unpleasant, but when he ceases to love, he becomes dishonest regarding the future—for which he made many promises with frequent vows and pleadings. Thus, while he was barely managing to get his beloved to tolerate the onerous relationship at the time on the basis of a hope for the benefits to come, when the time comes to pay up, since the lover has switched to a different ruler and commander in himself, namely, intelligence and judiciousness instead of love and madness, he has become a different person. His darling does not realize this and asks for a return on his kindness in earlier times, reminding him of what was said and done, as though he were talking to the same person. However, the lover is ashamed to admit straightforwardly that he has become a different person, nor can he make good the vows and promises he made when he was ruled by his earlier folly, having now recovered his mind and become judicious, lest by doing what he did then he again become the same person he was then. As a result of this the former lover runs away, and acts like someone compelled to default. When the shell falls with the other side up, he changes directions and departs in a rush.⁴⁶ The other, angry and calling upon the gods, is forced to pursue. From the beginning he has not understood that he should never have gratified a lover, who is inevitably out of his mind, but rather one who is in possession of his mind and not in love. To do the opposite is inevitably to enslave oneself to someone who is untrustworthy, peevish, jealous, disagreeable, harmful to one's property, harmful to one's physical condition, and above all harmful to the education of one's soul, than which there neither is nor ever will be anything that is truly more valuable to human beings or to the gods. 241a 241b 241c

So, dear boy, one must take these things into consideration and realize that the friendship of a lover does not come from goodwill, but from something like the desire for a satisfying meal. As wolves cherish lambs, so lovers befriend boys. 241d

That's it, *Phaedrus*! You won't hear another word from me! Let my speech for you end right there.

P: But I assumed that was its mid-point and you were about to make an equal number of points about the nonlover, mentioning his good qualities and

why one ought to gratify him rather than the other. So, why are you stopping now, Socrates?

S: Didn't you notice, you lucky fellow, that I've gone beyond a dithyrambic to an epic style,⁴⁷ and have done that while being critical? If I begin praising the other, what do you think I'll do? Do you see that I'll surely be possessed by the Nymphs to whom you deliberately threw me? So, I'll say it in a single sentence: whatever characteristics we condemned in the one, the opposite good characteristics are present in the other. Why make a long speech? What's been said is enough for both. So, my tale⁴⁸ shall suffer whatever it deserves, and I shall cross this stream and depart before you force me to do anything else. 241e 242a

P: Not yet, Socrates, while it's still so hot. Don't you see that it's already nearly noon, which is called the standing-still time?⁴⁹ Let's wait and discuss what's been said and leave a little later, after it cools off.

S: Phaedrus, you are simply amazing and have a superhuman⁵⁰ enthusiasm for speeches! Of the speeches that have been made during your lifetime, I suspect that no one's produced more than you, either by delivering them yourself or by compelling others to do so in one way or another. I except Simmias the Theban⁵¹ from the account, but you easily surpass the others. Now once again you seem to me to have become the cause of my making a speech. 242b

P: That's certainly not bad news! But how am I such a cause and what speech is this?

S: Just as I was about to cross the stream, my good man, my familiar daimonic sign came to me;⁵² it always holds me back from something I am about to do. All at once I seemed to hear a voice forbidding me to leave before I purify myself, as I have committed an offense against the divine. Now, I am a prophet, not a very serious one, but, like people who are barely literate, good enough for my own purposes. So, I already clearly understand my offense. In fact, my friend, the soul really is prophetic in a way. Even while I was delivering my speech I was troubled by something, and was concerned, as Ibycus⁵³ says, "that I might win honor among human beings by sinning against the gods." Now I perceive my offense. 242c 242d

P: What do you mean?

S: That terrible, terrible speech Phaedrus, both the one you brought and the one you forced me to deliver.

P: How is it so?

S: By being foolish and rather irreligious. What could be more terrible than that?

P: Nothing, if what you say is true.

S: Then what about this? Don't you believe that Love is the son of Aphrodite and is a god?⁵⁴

P: So it's said.

S: Not by Lysias, nor by your speech that was uttered by my mouth after it was bewitched by you. If Love is a god or something divine, as he surely is, 242e
he couldn't be evil, but both speeches just now spoke of him as though he were such. That was their offense in relation to Love. Yet their foolishness was very sophisticated; while saying what was neither sound nor true, they puffed themselves up like something important in the hope that they might 243a
deceive some little humanoids into having a high opinion of them. So, my friend, I must purify myself, and there's an ancient purification for those who give offense in tale-telling. Though Homer didn't know about it, Stesichorus⁵⁵ did. When the latter was struck blind for speaking ill of Helen, he wasn't, like Homer, ignorant of the reason, but, as one adept in the arts of the Muses, he knew, and promptly composed these lines:

That story was not true;
Neither did you step into the well-oared ships,
Nor did you come to the citadel of Troy. 243b

As soon as he had finished the entire so-called *Recantation*, he immediately recovered his sight. Now, I shall be wiser than they were in this matter. Before I suffer any punishment for my speaking ill of Love, I'll attempt to render my recantation to him, with my head bare and not hidden as before out of shame.

P: Nothing you could say would delight me more, Socrates.

S: That, good Phaedrus, is because you realize how shamelessly the two 243c
speeches were uttered, that last one and the one you read from the manuscript. If someone with a noble and gentle character, who loves or has ever loved another of the same sort, should hear us saying that lovers respond to small slights with great hostility and are jealous and harmful to their darlings, don't you think he'd believe he was listening to people brought up among sailors, who've never seen love among free men? Wouldn't he disagree strongly with 243d
our criticism of Love?

P: By Zeus, perhaps he would, Socrates.

S: Then, because I'm ashamed before that person and afraid of Love himself, I want to wash out the unpleasant taste of what we've heard with a fresh speech. I also advise Lysias to write as quickly as possible that, other things being equal, one ought to gratify a lover rather than a nonlover.

P: Be assured that that will be done. After you speak in praise of the lover, I shall most certainly make Lysias in turn write a speech on the same subject.

243e

S: I'm sure of that, as long as you are who you are.

P: Then speak with confidence.

S: Where's that boy of mine I was talking to? He must hear this also, lest from not hearing it he go and gratify the one who doesn't love.

P: He's always here, right beside you, whenever you want him.

S: Now then, my handsome boy, bear in mind that while the previous speech was by Phaedrus, the son of Pythocles, a man of Myrrinous, the one I am about to deliver is by Stesichorus, the son of Euphemus, of Himera.⁵⁶ And this is what must be said:

244a

That speech is not true which says that when a lover is at hand one ought instead to gratify someone who does not love, on the grounds that the former is mad and the other is in command of his senses. If it were a simple fact that madness is evil, that would be good advice, but as it is, the greatest goods come to us through the madness that is given as a divine gift.

The prophetess at Delphi and the priestesses at Dodona⁵⁷ have done many admirable things for Greece in public and private matters while they were mad, but little or nothing while in possession of their senses. If we should also speak of the Sibyl⁵⁸ and of others who through divinely inspired prophecy have foretold many things for many people and guided them into a better future, we would prolong a discussion of what is obvious to everyone. However, it is worth pointing out that the ancient people who gave things their names also believed that madness is neither shameful nor blameworthy; otherwise, they would not have connected the word itself with the noblest art, that by which the future is judged, by calling it the *manikēs* [mad] art. They gave it that name because they believed it a fine thing when it comes as a divine gift. The present generation, however, awkwardly inserts a 't' and calls it the *mantikēs* [prophetic] art. Moreover, the ancients called the art by which people seek out the future while in possession of their senses, using birds and other signs, *oionoistikēs* [augury] since they provide *nous* [intelligence] and *historia* [information] for humanly inspired *oiēsis* [speculation] through their *dianoia* [analysis], although modern people now call it *oiōnistikēs* [augury], making it sound more impressive by lengthening the second 'o.' Thus the ancients attest that as the prophetic art is more perfect and more valuable than the auguristic art, both in name and deed, so is the madness that comes from a god than the sanity that is of human origin.

244b

244c

244d

In the second place, madness has appeared in certain families that have

been afflicted with the greatest diseases and problems because of ancient provocations and, through prophecy, has found relief for those needing it by recourse to prayers and services for the gods. Thus, through purifications and rituals it happens upon, it makes those who are mad safe, both for the present and for the future, obtaining deliverance from their present afflictions for those who are maddened and possessed in the right way. 244e

A third kind of possession and madness comes from the Muses. It seizes a gentle, inexperienced soul and awakens within it a Bacchanalian enthusiasm for lyrical songs and other kinds of poetry, glorifying countless ancient deeds for the education of posterity. If anyone comes to the halls of poetry without the madness of the Muses, convinced that technique alone will make one a good poet, both the poetry of this man who is in possession of his senses and the man himself will fall short of perfection and be eclipsed by the poetry of those who are mad. 245a

In addition to these, I could tell you about many other examples of the admirable effect of the madness that comes from the gods. So, let us not fear that, and let us not be upset by any speech that tries to startle us with the claim that a judicious friend should be preferred to a passionate one. Let it carry off the spoils of victory when it has shown this in addition: that love is not sent from the gods for the benefit of the lover and the beloved. We must prove the opposite, that this sort of madness is given by the gods for the greatest possible good fortune. Our demonstration will not be believed by the clever, but it will be believed by the wise. 245b

First, then, we must determine the truth about the nature of a soul, both divine and human, by observing its experiences and its actions, and this is the beginning of our demonstration.

Every soul is immortal, for that which is always changing is immortal.⁵⁹ In the case of what changes other things or is changed by other things, when that stops changing, it stops living. Only what changes itself, since it needs nothing beyond itself, never stops changing. It is the source and origin⁶⁰ of change for the other things that change, but an origin is not a thing which comes into being. Everything that comes into being necessarily comes into being from an origin, but the latter does not itself come from an origin. For if an origin came into being from something, it would not come into being from an origin.⁶¹ Since it does not come into being, it also necessarily does not perish. If the origin were destroyed, it could never come into being from anything nor could anything else come into being from it, since everything must come into being from an origin. Therefore, the origin of change must be what changes itself, and it is not possible for this to be destroyed or to come into being. Otherwise, the entire universe and everything that comes into being would collapse into a static condition and that which is changed would never again come into being.⁶² Now, since what is changed by itself has been shown to be immortal, one is not ashamed to say that this very characteristic consti- 245c

tutes the essence and definition of the soul.⁶³ Every object that is changed from without lacks a soul, but every object in which change comes from within itself has a soul, as that is the nature of the soul. If this is so, then, and what changes itself is none other than the soul, a soul would by necessity be something that does not come into being and is immortal. 246a

As for the immortality of the soul, then, that is enough, but as for its form, we must say the following. To specify what sort of thing it is would by all means be a task for a god and a lengthy exposition, but to say what it is like would be briefer and is something a human being could do. So, let us take the latter approach. Compare it to the combined capacities of a team of winged horses and their winged charioteer. Now, all the horses and charioteers of the gods are good and of good stock, but in other cases they are of mixed quality. In our case, the driver holds the reins of a pair of horses, one of which is noble and good and of similar stock, while the other is of the opposite stock and opposite in character. Thus, the driving in our case is inevitably difficult and troublesome. 246b

Now, we must try to explain why we speak of mortal as well as immortal living beings.⁶⁴ Every soul travels around the entire heavens, appearing in different forms at different times, and cares for everything that lacks a soul. When a soul is perfect and has its wings, it travels through the sky and takes part in the governance of the entire cosmos, but if it loses its wings it drifts along until it can grasp onto something secure and settle down. There, it takes on an earthly body which then seems to move itself because of the soul's power. This united whole of a soul and a body fastened together is called a living being and has the name "mortal." We are unable to give a coherent account of an immortal being, but, although we have never seen and cannot adequately conceive of a god, we fashion an idea of a sort of immortal living being that has a soul and a body which are joined together eternally. But let that and the way it is spoken of be as suits the god.⁶⁵ 246c

Let us consider instead the reason why a soul loses its wings, why they fall off. It is something like this. The natural function of a wing is to carry what is heavy upward and raise it to the region where the race of the gods dwells. In a way, they have more in common with the divine than any other bodily part, and since the divine is noble, wise, good, and everything else of that sort, such things are very nourishing to the wings of the soul and make them grow, while shame, evil, and other things of the opposite sort are detrimental and can even destroy them completely. 246e

The mighty Zeus takes the lead in the journeys through the heavens, driving his winged chariot and arranging and managing everything. A host of gods and other divine beings follow him, arranged in eleven groups. Hestia stays behind alone in the dwelling-place of the gods, but the others who are ranked among the twelve as ruling gods lead the way, according to the position each has been assigned.⁶⁶ Many and blessed are the sights along the high- 247a

ways on this side of the heavens, and the happy race of the gods ranges among them, each performing its own task. Whoever is able and willing follows them, since jealousy has no place in the company of the divine. Whenever they go to a feast or banquet, they travel directly to the highest point, the summit of the arch that supports the heavens. The evenly balanced chariots of the gods, with their tractable teams, make the journey with ease, but the others have difficulty. The horse with bad character is heavy and, if it was not well trained by its charioteer, it sinks down and drags him toward the earth, where hard toil and an arduous testing await the soul. When those that are called the immortals reach the summit, they go outside and stand on the back of the heavens.⁶⁷ While they stand there, the revolution of the heavens carries them round, and they study what lies beyond the heavens.

Of that place beyond the heavens none of this world's poets has yet sung worthily, nor shall any ever do so. But it is like this—for one must dare to speak the truth, and especially when the subject is the truth itself. That place is occupied by the being that really is, which is intangible and without color or shape. It is perceived only by the intellect, the pilot of the soul, and is the object of the true kind of knowledge. The mind of a god, which draws its nourishment from intelligence and pure knowledge, and that of every soul that cares about getting what is proper for it, cherishes the opportunity to observe what is and is nourished and happy while it studies the truth during the time it takes the circular revolution to carry it back to its starting point. On its circular journey, it sees justice itself, it sees judiciousness, and it sees knowledge, not the knowledge that is connected with becoming and varies with the varying things we now say are, but rather the knowledge that exists in the realm of what really is and really is knowledge. When it has studied and enjoyed the other things that really are, it returns to the region within the heavens and goes home. When it arrives there, the charioteer stations his horses at their feeding trough, puts ambrosia before them, and gives them nectar to drink. Such is the life of the gods.

As for the other souls, the one that most closely follows and best resembles its god lifts its charioteer's head into the outer region and is carried around the circuit, although it has trouble with its horses and hardly sees the things that are. Another soul at times rises and at times sinks because its horses are unruly, and it sees some things but not others. All the rest follow behind, trying to reach the upper region but unable to do so. They are carried around together beneath it trampling and jostling one another as each tries to get ahead. So, there is great clamor and conflict, and much sweating, and because they have bad charioteers, many are maimed and many break their wing-feathers. Despite much effort, all these finish the journey without being initiated into the vision of what is, and afterward they feed on mere opinion.

The reason for the great eagerness to see the plain of truth is that the meadow there provides the pasturage that is appropriate for the best part of the

soul and the nature of the wing that carries the soul aloft is nourished by this.

The decree of Adrasteia⁶⁸ is as follows. The soul that has seen some of the truth by joining a god on the journey will be free from suffering until the next revolution, and if it can continue to do this forever, it will always be free from harm. Whenever it is unable to follow so that it does not see and through some misfortune is burdened with forgetfulness and evil, and because of the heavy burden loses its wings and falls to the earth, then the rule is this: In its first birth this sort of soul is never implanted in a wild animal, but rather the one that has seen the most is implanted in a seed that will become a man who 248d is a friend of wisdom⁶⁹ or of beauty or else someone devoted to the Muses and the affairs of love. The next in order is implanted in the seed of a law-abiding king or a military commander; the third in that of a politician, a manager, or a businessman; the fourth in that of an athlete who is a friend of exercise or else of someone who will cure the ills of the body; the fifth will lead a life involved with prophecy or the mysteries; for the sixth the life of a poet or of 248e someone else involved with the imitative arts will be fitting; for the seventh that of an artisan or farmer; for the eighth that of a Sophist or a demagogue; for the ninth that of a tyrant. In every case, whoever lives justly receives a better fate, and whoever lives unjustly, a worse.

A soul does not return to the place from which it came for ten thousand years, because it takes that long for it to regain its wings—except for the one 249a that has a pure friendship with wisdom or combines its love for young boys with a friendship with wisdom. If they choose this sort of life three times, then these souls will depart after the third revolution of a thousand years, having regained their wings in three thousand years. The others, however, when they have completed their first life, are brought to judgment, and after they are judged, some go to the places of punishment beneath the earth to serve their sentence, while others are borne aloft by Dike⁷⁰ to a certain region under the heavens where they pass their lives in the manner merited by the life they lived in human form. After a thousand years both come to the casting of lots 249b for the choice of their second life, and each chooses as it wishes. Here a human soul may enter into the life of a wild animal and what was at one time a human being may return from a wild animal into a human being again. However, a soul that has never seen the truth cannot take on this latter form, because a human being must acquire understanding of what is said through principles drawn together by reasoning into a unity out of the multiplicity of 249c perceptions. This is a recollection of what our soul saw when it was travelling with a god, looking down on the things we now say are and rising up into what really is. For this reason it is proper that only the thinking of the friend of wisdom will make the wings grow, because, through memory, it is always as close as possible to that which by its proximity makes a god divine. When a man deals correctly with remembrances of this sort, he is always initiated perfectly into perfect mysteries, and he alone really becomes perfect. Since he

stands apart from the busy antics of humankind and draws close to the divine, he is rebuked by most people for being out of his wits. They do not realize that he is possessed. 249d

So then, the whole speech up to this point has been about a fourth kind of madness. Whenever someone sees beauty in this world he is reminded of true beauty and his wing-feathers grow. When he has regained his wings he longs to fly up, but he is unable to and gazes upward like a bird, not caring for the things below, and for this reason is regarded as mad. Of all the kinds of possession this is the best and is from the best source, both for the one who has it and for the one who shares in it, and it is because of his participating in this kind of madness that the one who loves the beautiful is called a lover. For, as has been said, every soul of a human being by virtue of its nature has seen the things that are, otherwise it could not have entered into this kind of living being; but it is not easy for every soul to recall those things on the basis of the things of this world. Some barely saw the things there at the time, and others who fell to earth had the misfortune of being corrupted by some of their associations and have forgotten the sacred things they saw before. Few are left who have much of a memory of them, and they, when they see some likeness of those things, are astounded and delirious, although they do not understand the experience because their perception is so unclear. Thus, there is no enlightenment in this world's images of justice, judiciousness, and all the other things souls value. However, as they approach these resemblances with their feeble organs, a few do with difficulty see the original through the resemblance, although earlier, when we were following Zeus while others followed another of the gods, there was a brilliantly shining beauty to see. When we saw those blessed visions with that happy company we were initiated into the mysteries Themis⁷¹ says are the most blessed, and we celebrated those rites while we were whole in every way and unacquainted with the evils that awaited us in another time. Whole also, and simple, steadfast, and blessed were those visions in the pure brilliant light when we were initiated and admitted into the highest mysteries, and we ourselves were also pure and unmarred by that which we call the body and now carry around, imprisoned within it like an oyster in its shell. 249e
250a
250b
250c

Let that be our tribute to memory, then, for the sake of which, and because of a longing for those earlier times, such a lengthy statement has been made. Concerning beauty, as we said, it shone brightly along with those things, and, since coming here, we have grasped it shining most distinctly through the most distinct of our senses. For sight is the keenest of the sensations coming to us through the body. Wisdom is not visible to it because the sort of clear image of itself that would be required for sight would provoke terrible, loving desires, as would be the case with any other of those objects of love. It is beauty alone which has that fate, and thus is the most evident and the loveliest. 250d
250e

When the person who was not recently initiated, or who has been corrupted, sees the namesake of beauty in this world, he is not swiftly carried from here to beauty itself in that other place; so he feels no awe when looking at its namesake. Instead, he abandons himself to pleasure and tries to mount others in the manner of a four-footed beast and to sow his seed. He takes *hubris* as his companion and is neither afraid nor ashamed to pursue a pleasure that is contrary to nature. However, when the recent initiate, who saw many things in that early time, sees a godlike face or some form of body that imitates beauty well, he at first gets goose bumps and something of the earlier dread comes upon him. He is awestruck, as though he were gazing upon a god, and, if he were not afraid that people would think he was a raving maniac, he would offer sacrifice to his darling as to a sacred statue or a god. As he looks at him, his goose bumps go away and an unusual warmth and sweating seizes him. He is warmed by the effluence of beauty he receives through his eyes, which naturally moistens the wing-feathers. As he grows warmer, the follicles, which had earlier hardened and closed so that the feathers could not sprout, are softened; and as the nourishing moisture flows over them, the shafts of the feathers swell and begin to grow from their roots over the entire form of the soul, which was feathered all over before. 251a 251b

At this point the entire soul is throbbing with excitement. It is like the experience of cutting teeth and the itching and irritation that occur around the gums when the teeth are just coming through. The soul of the one who is beginning to sprout feathers itches and is irritated and excited as it grows its wings. Whenever it looks at the boy's beauty, it takes in a flood of particles flowing from him (which is why longing is called a flood of passion) and is nourished and warmed by it, and it obtains relief from its pain and rejoices. When it is alone and dries out, however, the openings of the passages through which the feathers push their way out become quite dry and close up, shutting the shoots of the feathers up inside. The shoots, which are imprisoned with the flood of passion, pulsate like throbbing arteries, and each presses against the outlet of its passage, so that the entire soul is driven to a frenzy by the pain of the prickling all over it. Yet when it again remembers the beauty of the boy, it rejoices, although it is perplexed and troubled by the oddness of an experience that is a mixture of both these conditions. In its agony, it cannot sleep at night nor stay in one place during the day. Filled with longing, it runs wherever it thinks it might see the one who possesses beauty. When it sees him and is bathed with a flood of passion, the openings that had been tightly closed are released; it gains release from the pressures and pangs, and at that moment savors the sweetest of pleasures. It will not leave him willingly and values nothing more highly than the beauty of the boy. On the contrary, it forgets mother, brothers, and all associates, and if its property is lost through neglect thinks nothing of it. It now despises customary decency and taste, which it used to take great pride in, and is ready to be a slave and sleep wherever it is 251c 251d 251e 252a

allowed to, as near as possible to the object of its longing. It not only is in awe of the one who possesses beauty; it finds in him the only healer of its greatest sufferings.

252b

Well, you beautiful boy, for whom my speech is given, human beings call this experience “love,” but when you hear what the gods call it, because of your youth, you will probably laugh. I believe some of the Homericists quote two verses to Love from the secret epics, of which the second is quite hubristic and not very metrical. They sing as follows:

Mortals do indeed call the winged one *Erōs* (Love),
But immortals call him *Pterōs* (Feathered), because
he necessarily develops wings.⁷²

You may believe these verses or not, but the cause and the nature of lovers’ experience are as I have stated.

252c

Now, whoever is seized from among the attendants of Zeus is able to bear the burden of the one named Pteros in a more dignified manner, but when those who were the servants of Ares⁷³ and made the circuit with him are captured by Love and think they have been wronged in some way by the one they love, they become murderous and ready to sacrifice both themselves and their darlings. Thus, so long as he remains uncorrupted during his first life in this world, each person lives in accordance with the manner of the god whose procession he had been part of, honoring and imitating the god as far as possible, and he behaves this way in his relations with those he loves and with everyone else as well. Each person selects his love from the ranks of the beautiful according to his own style, and he fashions his own sacred statue, as it were, adorning it and holding ritual celebrations in its honor, as though the beloved were himself the god.

252d

The followers of Zeus want the person they love to be a Zeus-like soul. So, they search for one who has the nature of a friend of wisdom and a leader, and when they find such a person they love him and do everything they can to encourage him along that path. If they have not done this before, they now set out to learn what they can from whatever source is available and to figure things out for themselves. They have ample resources within themselves for their search for one with the nature of their own god because they are compelled to keep their eyes fixed on their god. Holding onto their memory of him, they are inspired by him and derive their customs and practices from him, insofar as it is possible for a human being to be like a god, and since they take the beloved to be the cause of all this, they cherish him even more. They draw refreshing drink from Zeus and, like the devotees of Bacchus, pour it into the soul of their beloved, making him as similar as possible to their god.

252e

253a

253b

Those who followed Hera seek a regal person, and when they find one, they do all the same things for him. So also the followers of Apollo⁷⁴ and each of the other gods go out and seek their own boy whose nature accords with

that of their god, and when they have acquired one, by imitating the god themselves and through persuasion and training, they lead their darlings into the practice and style of the god, as far as each can do so. They are never jealous or spiteful in relation to their darlings, but rather expend all their effort in the attempt to guide him into being as similar as possible to themselves and the god they honor. Thus the desire of true lovers and the initiation of the one who is befriended by his friend who has been driven mad by love are beautiful things and lead to their happiness, if they accomplish what they desire in the way I describe—if he is captured, that is. And the one who is caught is captured in the following way. 253c

Just as at the beginning of this tale we divided each soul into three parts, two in the form of horses and the third in the form of a charioteer, so now let us continue with these. Of the horses, we say that one is good and the other not, but we have not described the goodness of the good one nor the badness of the bad. Now we must do so. Well, then, the one has a more beautiful stance, with correct conformation and good development. It carries its neck high, is somewhat hook-nosed and light in color, and it has dark eyes. It is a lover of honor conjoined with judiciousness and a sense of what is respectable and is a companion of what is truly reputable. It needs no whip but is driven simply by a word of command. The other, however, is crooked in conformation, gross, and awkwardly constructed with a thick, short neck, a flat nose, dark skin, and grey, bloodshot eyes. A companion of *hubris* and insolence, it is shaggy-eared and deaf and barely responds to a combination of whip and goad. 253e

So, when the charioteer sees the vision of his beloved, his entire soul is warmed by the perception and filled with longing's tickling and prickling. The horse that is obedient to the charioteer, constrained now as always by a sense of what is respectable, restrains itself, not leaping upon the beloved; but the other no longer heeds the charioteer's whip and goad. It leaps forward powerfully, giving its yoke-mate and the charioteer all kinds of trouble, and forces them to approach the darling and mention to him the delights of sexual activity. At first the two indignantly resist being compelled to do terrible, unlawful things, but they finally give in to the unending harassment and go where they are being led, agreeing to do what is demanded. Thus, they come close to the darling and see his radiant face. 254a 254b

When the charioteer sees him, he is reminded of the nature of beauty and sees it again, standing on its sacred pedestal beside judiciousness. Fearful and awestricken at the sight, he falls back, and this forces him to pull on the reins with sufficient violence to set both horses back on their haunches, the one willingly, because it does not resist, but the hubristic one very much against its will. As they move back a bit, the entire soul is drenched with sweat because of the shame and alarm of the one horse, but the other, barely having recovered its breath as the pain from the bit and its fall diminishes, angrily 254c

rails against its charioteer and yoke-mate, heaping abuse upon them as unmanly cowards for backing out of the arrangement they had agreed upon. It again forces its unwilling partners forward and only reluctantly gives in when they beg it to postpone the project until later. Then, when the appointed time comes and they pretend not to remember, it forcefully reminds them, neighing and pulling them until it again forces them to approach the darling with the same propositions. When they get close to him, it takes the bit in its teeth, and with head down and tail stretched out it shamelessly drags them forward. But the charioteer has the same reaction as before, even more violently, and like a chariot-race driver recoiling from the barrier he jerks the bit back even more violently than before and forces it from between the teeth of the hubristic horse, bloodying its abusive tongue and jaws, forcing its legs and haunches firmly to the ground, and tormenting it with pain. After it experiences this same treatment many times, the wicked horse abandons its *hubris* and humbly obeys the intentions of the charioteer. Now when it sees the beautiful boy it is consumed with fear, and from then on the soul of the lover follows its darling in respectful awe.

Thus, a lover takes care of all his darling's needs and treats him like an equal of the gods, because he is not pretending but truly loves him, and the darling himself naturally becomes a friend to the one who cares for him. Even if he has rejected his lover in the past, deceived by schoolmates and others who said it is shameful to associate with a lover, yet, as time goes along, destiny and increasing maturity lead him to accept his lover into his company. For it is fated that bad is never to be a friend to bad nor good not to be a friend to good. When he has accepted the lover and enjoyed his conversation and his company, the goodwill of the lover that is revealed in their close relationship amazes the beloved, and he discovers that all his other friends and relatives offer no friendship at all in comparison with this friend who is divinely inspired. As the relationship continues and he comes close to his lover and touches him at the gymnasium and in other places where they associate, then the flow of that stream which Zeus as the lover of Ganymede⁷⁵ named "the flood of passion" surges in abundance upon his lover. Some of it enters into the lover, and when he is filled to the brim, some of it spills over; and as the wind or an echo rebounds from smooth, hard surfaces to the place from whence it originated, so the stream of beauty returns to the beautiful darling through his eyes, which is the natural route to the soul. Arriving there and setting him all aflutter, it moistens the passages of the feathers and causes the wings to grow and in turn fills the soul of the beloved with love.

So, he loves, yet he is at a loss as to what he loves. He neither knows what has happened to him nor can he explain it. He is like someone who has caught an eye infection from someone else and cannot account for it. He does not realize that he is seeing himself in his lover as in a mirror. When his lover is present, he feels the same cessation of pain that his lover does, and when his

lover is away he again shares his lover's longing and being longed for in the same way. He possesses a love-response that is the reflection of love, but he supposes it to be friendship rather than love and calls it that. He feels a desire like that of his lover, though less strong, to see, to touch, to kiss,⁷⁶ to lie beside him; and, as is to be expected, soon afterwards he does just that. 255e

When they are lying together, the lover's undisciplined horse tells the charioteer that it thinks it deserves to enjoy a little pleasure in return for all its suffering. The darling's undisciplined horse says nothing, and the darling, full to bursting and at a loss as to why, embraces his lover and kisses him, welcoming him as a person with the best intentions. While they are lying together, the darling's undisciplined horse would not refuse its part in gratifying the lover, if the darling should ask, although its good yoke-mate in turn, along with the charioteer, opposes this with modesty and reason. Now, if the better aspects of the mind prevail by leading them into an orderly life and a friendship with wisdom, they will lead a blessed and harmonious life here. By binding that by which evil comes into the soul and setting free that by which goodness comes in, they become well-disciplined and orderly. When they have accomplished this, they will have shed their burdens and will recover their wings, and they will have won the first of the three rounds in that truly Olympian struggle. Neither human judiciousness nor divine madness can provide a human being with any greater good than that. 256a 256b

If on the other hand, they engage in a coarser way of life, befriending not wisdom but fame and honor, then perhaps sometime when they are drunk or at some other careless moment the undisciplined horses in the two of them may catch their souls off guard, bring them together, take the choice most people call a blessed thing, and carry through on the act. Having once done this, they continue doing it in the future, though rarely, since what they are doing has not been decided by their whole mind. These two are also friends, then, though less so than the other pair, and remain together both while they are in love and after love has departed, for they believe they have each given and received the strongest vows, which it would be unlawful to break by ever becoming enemies. In the end they lack their wings, but they emerge from the body with the impulse to grow wings, so they carry away no small prize from their erotic madness. The rule is that those who have already begun the journey up toward the heavens shall not go down into the darkness of the journey under the earth, but rather they shall continue their illustrious life, happily travelling together. When they gain their wings they shall do so together because of their love. 256c 256d 256e

Things such as these, then, my boy, divine things, the friendship of a lover will bring to you, but a relationship with one who does not love, diluted with a mortal judiciousness and dispensing benefits that are both mortal and miserly, produces in the soul of the befriended that servile condition most people praise as a virtue that will cause it to wander mindlessly around the earth and beneath it for nine thousand years. 257a

This recantation is offered and paid to you, Love my friend, as the best and most beautiful we are capable of. In language and in other ways it was forced to be somewhat poetical because of *Phaedrus*. Forgive what occurred earlier and be favorable toward this. Be merciful and gracious, and do not in anger take away or diminish the skill in the art of love that you have given me. Grant that I be even more highly esteemed than now by those who are beautiful. If *Phaedrus* and I said anything harsh about you in the earlier speech, blame *Lysias* as the father of that speech. Make him cease from such speeches and turn him toward friendship with wisdom, as his brother *Polemarchus*⁷⁷ has been turned, so that his lover here will no longer be ambivalent, as he is now, but rather will dedicate his life entirely to love through speeches that are characterized by friendship with wisdom. 257b

P: I join with you in that prayer, *Socrates*, if in fact we will be better off should those things happen. But for some time now I've been amazed by how much finer an achievement this speech is than your earlier one. I'm afraid *Lysias* would seem inferior by comparison, if he should be willing to match another speech of his own against it. In fact, you amazing man, one of the politicians was recently criticizing him for this very thing, referring to him throughout his diatribe as a speech-writer. As a result, he may refrain from writing any more for us out of a concern for his friendship with fame and honor.⁷⁸ 257c

S: That's ridiculous, young man! You're way off in your opinion of your associate if you think he'll be frightened by that sort of noise. However, you're probably assuming that his accuser meant what he said as a criticism. 257d

P: He did give me that impression, *Socrates*, and you're well aware yourself that the people with the greatest power and dignity in our cities are ashamed to write speeches and to leave written works behind them because they're afraid they may be called *Sophists* by posterity.

S: It's like Pleasant Bend, *Phaedrus*. You've forgotten that it's the long bend in the Nile that's called that,⁷⁹ and besides the matter of the bend you've forgotten that those politicians who think most highly of themselves dearly love writing speeches and leaving written works behind them. In fact, whenever they write a speech they so cherish those who praise it that, on each occasion, they add at the beginning the names of those who commend them. 257e

P: What do you mean? I don't understand.

S: You don't understand that at the beginning of a politician's composition the name of its admirer is written first. 258a

P: How so?

S: The writer says something like "it was resolved by the council" (or

“by the people” or both) and “proposed by so-and-so,” very solemnly stating his own name and eulogizing himself. Then, after that, he states what he has to say, showing off his own wisdom to his admirers and sometimes producing a very lengthy composition. Does it seem to you that this sort of thing is anything other than a written speech?

P: Not to me.

258b

S: When it holds up, the author leaves the stage rejoicing, but if it's knocked down, he loses his status as a speech writer and isn't considered good enough to be an author. Then he and his associates go into mourning.

P: Most certainly.

S: Clearly, not as people who despise the practice, but as people who admire it.

P: Definitely.

S: And what about this? When an orator or king succeeds in gaining the power of a Lycurgus, a Solon, or a Darius,⁸⁰ and acquires immortality in his city as a speech writer, doesn't he then think of himself as an equal of the gods even while he's still alive and doesn't posterity think about him the same way when they study his writings?

258c

P: Most certainly.

S: Then, do you think that anyone of that sort, whoever he is and however much he dislikes Lysias, would criticize him on that basis, that he's a writer?

P: From what you're saying, it's not very likely, for it seems he'd be criticizing the object of his own desires.

S: This then, should be clear to everyone, that there's nothing shameful about the activity of writing speeches as such.

258d

P: How could there be?

S: What is shameful, I take it, is speaking and writing, not well, but shamefully and badly.

P: Obviously so.

S: Then, how does one write well or badly? Do we need to consult Lysias about this question, Phaedrus, and anyone else who has written or will someday write something, whether a composition about public or private affairs, whether in verse as a poet or without it as an ordinary writer?

P: Are you asking whether we ought to do this? What would one live for,

258e

I would say, if not for the sake of such pleasures? Surely, one wouldn't live for the sake of those pleasures that can be enjoyed only after pain, which is the case for nearly all bodily pleasures and is why they are rightly called slavish.

S: Well, we seem to have some free time. Moreover, as the cicadas above our heads sing and converse with each other in the summer heat, they also seem to me to be watching us. If they should see us not conversing but drowsily dozing under their spell like most people at midday, they'd justly laugh at us, thinking we were a couple of slaves visiting their retreat by the spring for a noontime nap, like sheep. If, however, they see us conversing and sailing by them without falling under their Siren-like spell,⁸¹ then in admiration they may grant us the gift they have from the gods to give to human beings. 259a 259b

P: What's this gift they have? I don't think I've heard of it.

S: No? It's really inexcusable for a man who's a friend of the Muses not to have heard of such things. It's said that before the Muses existed, these cicadas were human beings, but after the Muses were born and singing made its appearance, some people in those days were so overwhelmed by the pleasure of it that they were caught up in singing and forgot to eat or drink and died before they realized what was happening. The race of the cicadas then developed from them, and they received from the Muses this gift of not needing any food from their birth, so that they sing continuously without eating or drinking until they die. Afterwards they go and report to the Muses who among those here honors each of them. They report to Terpsichore those who have honored her in the choral dance, disposing her to be more friendly to them, and they report to Erato those who have honored her in the affairs of love, and so on to the others, according to the form of honor belonging to each. To Calliope, the oldest, and to Ourania, who comes after her, they report those who spend their time in friendship with wisdom, honoring the arts connected with these two, who most among the Muses are concerned with the heavens and with speeches divine and human and whose song is the most beautiful. So, there are many reasons why we should talk and not take a midday nap. 259c

P: We should talk, surely.

S: Then, we must examine the question we just now proposed for investigation, namely, what constitutes speaking and writing well or badly. 259e

P: Obviously.

S: Then, for things that are going to be said properly and well, mustn't there be knowledge of the truth in the mind of the speaker about the subject he intends to speak on?

P: In that regard, Socrates my friend, I've heard that it isn't necessary for one who intends to be an orator to understand what's really just, but only what 260a

would seem so to the masses who'll be passing judgment, nor what's really good or beautiful but what will seem so. It's from the latter, and not from the truth, that persuasion derives.

S: Anything wise men say, Phaedrus, is definitely "not a word to be cast aside."⁸² We must examine it, in case they're saying something worthwhile, and in particular we mustn't dismiss what's just been said.

P: What you're saying is right.

S: Then, let's examine it this way.

P: How?

S: If I were trying to persuade you to defend yourself in battles by acquiring a horse and neither of us knew what a horse was, but I did happen to know this much about you, that Phaedrus thinks a horse is the domestic animal with the longest ears... 260b

P: That would be ridiculous, Socrates.

S: Not yet; but if I were seriously trying to persuade you by composing a speech in praise of the donkey, labelling it a horse and saying that the beast would be a highly valuable acquisition both for at home and in the army, useful as a mount in battle and able to carry your equipment, and beneficial for many other purposes... 260c

P: That would indeed be utterly ridiculous.

S: Well, isn't it better to be ridiculous and friendly rather than clever and hostile?

P: That seems evident.

S: Then, when an orator who is ignorant about good and evil encounters a city in the same condition and tries to persuade it by offering praises, not of the specter of a donkey as though it were a horse, but of what is evil as though it were good, and by catering to the opinions of the masses, he persuades it to do evil rather than good, what sort of harvest do you suppose his rhetoric will reap from what it has sowed? 260d

P: Not a very satisfactory one.

S: Well now, my good man, have we abused the art of making speeches⁸³ more roughly than we should? Perhaps it might reply: "Why are you amazing fellows being so foolish? I force no one to remain ignorant of the truth while learning how to speak. On the contrary, if my advice is of value, it's to take me on after acquiring the truth. What I emphasize is this: Without me, the person who knows how things are will be of no account in the art of persuasion."

P: Well, if it says that, won't that be a just response? 260e

S: I'll say so, if the arguments advancing toward it testify that it is an art.⁸⁴ I seem, as it were, to hear certain arguments approaching and protesting that it's lying and isn't an art but an artless routine. As the Spartan says, there is not and never shall be a genuine art of speaking apart from a grasp of the truth.⁸⁵

P: We need those arguments, Socrates. Lead them here and examine their meaning carefully. 261a

S: Come forward, noble creatures, and persuade Phaedrus, who has such beautiful children,⁸⁶ that unless he develops a satisfactory friendship with wisdom, he will never speak satisfactorily about anything. Let Phaedrus answer.

P: Ask your questions.

S: Well then, isn't rhetoric as a whole a sort of art of leading souls by means of speeches, not only in the law courts and other such public assemblies, but also in private situations? Doesn't the same art deal with both major and minor matters, so that using it correctly is no more important in connection with significant matters than in connection with trivial ones? What've you heard about this? 261b

P: Not that, by Zeus, not that at all! Certainly, one can speak and write artfully in connection with lawsuits, and also one can speak in an artful manner before public assemblies, but I've not heard of extending it beyond that.

S: Can it be that you've heard only of the treatises on the art of making speeches by Nestor and Odysseus, which they composed during their free time in Troy? Haven't you heard of those of Palamedes?⁸⁷

P: No, by Zeus, nor have I heard of Nestor's unless you're casting Gorgias as Nestor and Thrasymachus and Theodorus as Odysseus.⁸⁸ 261c

S: Perhaps, but let's leave them aside. Tell me, what are the contending parties in the law courts doing? Aren't they just contradicting each other? What should we say?

P: Just that.

S: About what's just and unjust?

P: Yes.

S: Then, the person who does this artfully can make the same thing appear to the same people as just at one time and unjust at another, as he wishes? 261d

P: Of course.

S: In public assemblies he can make the same things seem good to the city at one time and the opposite at another time?

P: So he can.

S: Then, don't we know that the Eleatic Palamedes speaks artfully when he makes the same things appear to his hearers as both similar and dissimilar, one and many, and at rest and in motion?

P: Certainly.

S: So, the art of contradicting is not only connected with the law courts and public assemblies. On the contrary, there seems to be this single art, if it is an art, that is connected with every kind of speaking. By means of it anyone whatsoever can make everything that is capable of it appear similar to everything else it is capable of resembling, and he can expose anyone else who makes one thing similar to another and tries to hide what he's doing. 261e

P: What exactly do you mean?

S: I think the point can be made clear by searching in this direction. Does deception occur more often when there's a great difference between things or when there's little difference?

P: When there's little. 262a

S: So, if you move across to an opposite position by small steps, you're more likely to escape detection than if you make the transition by large steps.

P: Of course.

S: Then, the person who intends to deceive someone else, but not to be deceived himself, must have an accurate knowledge of the similarity and dissimilarity of things.

P: Necessarily.

S: Will such a person, if he is ignorant of the truth about each thing, be able to recognize the similarity to other things, whether small or great, of the thing he's ignorant about?

P: That would be impossible. 262b

S: When people are deceived and their opinions are contrary to the facts, it's clear that this condition slips in as a result of certain similarities.

P: Surely, that's how it happens.

S: If a person who possesses this art doesn't know what each thing is, is it possible for him to carry people along in small steps by means of similarities, leading them on each occasion away from what's so to the opposite, or to avoid this himself?

P: No, never.

S: Then, my friend, the person who doesn't know the truth and has gone chasing after opinions will provide a ridiculous and, so it seems, artless art of making speeches. 262c

P: That seems likely.

S: Well, do you want to look in Lysias' speech that you're carrying and in the speeches we've given for examples of what we're calling artless or artful?

P: By all means! At present we're talking rather abstractly, because we don't have appropriate examples.

S: Why, then it seems it's by a bit of luck that the two speeches that have been given contain an example of how someone who knows the truth can mislead his audience by playing around with words. I myself, Phaedrus, credit the gods of this place, and perhaps also those representatives of the Muses singing overhead who may have inspired us with this gift. I myself surely don't share in any art of speaking. 262d

P: That may be as you say; only make clear what you mean.

S: Read me the beginning of Lysias' speech.

P: "You understand my situation, and you have heard how I think it would be to our advantage for this to happen. Because I am not your lover, I deserve not to be disappointed in what I request. When lovers' desires cease, they regret..." 262e

S: Stop. We must say how Lysias misses the mark and produces something artless, mustn't we?

P: Yes. 263a

S: Well then, isn't the following obvious to everyone, namely, that about some things of this sort we are in agreement, but about others we take opposing positions?

P: I think I understand what you're saying, but clarify it further.

S: When someone says the word 'iron' or 'silver,' don't we all think of the same things?

P: Certainly.

S: What about 'just' or 'good'? Don't we go off in different directions and disagree with one another and even with ourselves?

P: Definitely.

S: So on some matters we agree, but on others we don't? 263b

P: That's so.

S: In which, then, are we more easily deceived, and in which is rhetoric more potent?

P: Obviously, in those on which we keep changing our position.

S: Then, the person who intends to pursue the rhetorical art must first make a thorough survey of these matters and find some distinguishing mark of each of the two kinds of issues, that is, the kind on which most people inevitably change their position and that on which they don't.

P: The person who grasps that, Socrates, will surely have learned a fine thing. 263c

S: Next, I suppose, in each case he must pay attention and note precisely to which of the two kinds the subject he intends to speak about belongs.

P: Of course.

S: Well then, shall we say that love is one of the things people take opposing positions about, or not?

P: One of the things people take opposing positions about, surely. Otherwise how could you get away with saying what you did earlier about it, that it's harmful to both the beloved and the lover and then on the other hand that it's the greatest of good things?

S: You make an excellent point! But tell me this also, since because of my inspired state at the time I don't remember at all, did I define love at the beginning of my speech? 263d

P: You did, by Zeus, quite emphatically.

S: Ah! So you claim that the Nymphs, who are the daughters of Achei-
lous, and Pan, the son of Hermes,⁸⁹ are much more artful in making speeches
than is Lysias, son of Cephalus. Or am I speaking nonsense? Did Lysias also
at the beginning of his erotic speech compel us to take love as one definite
thing, which he had a conception of, and then proceed to finish his speech,
arranging everything to fit in with this? Do you want us to read the beginning
of his speech again? 263e

P: If you think we should, but what you're looking for isn't in it.

S: Speak, please, so that I can hear the man himself.

P: "You understand my situation, and you have heard how I think it would be to our advantage for this to happen. Because I am not your lover, I

deserve not to be disappointed in what I request. When lovers' desires cease, they regret their earlier generosity,..." 264a

S: Why, he seems to be a long way from doing what we're looking for. He's trying to swim through the speech on his back in reverse, starting from the end rather than from the beginning. He begins with what the lover should say to his darling at the conclusion. Or is what I'm saying not so, Phaedrus my chief friend?

P: Indeed, Socrates, he does begin his speech with the conclusion. 264b

S: What about other matters? Don't the sections of the speech seem to have been thrown together randomly? Does there appear to be any necessity for what comes second in his remarks being placed second, rather than one of the other things he says? It seemed to me, as one who knows nothing about it, that the writer just said whatever occurred to him, though in a not unrefined manner. Do you know of some necessity of speechwriting on the basis of which he placed these points beside one another in this order?

P: You're kind to believe that I am capable of making such a precise critique of his work. 264c

S: I suppose you could say this, that every speech ought to be organized like a living being with its own body, lacking neither head nor feet, but having both a middle and extremities, written so as to complement both each other and the whole.

P: Of course.

S: Then, examine whether or not your associate's speech has that characteristic. You'll find that it doesn't differ at all from the epitaph some say is inscribed on the tomb of Midas the Phrygian.

P: What epitaph is that, and what's the matter with it? 264d

S: It goes like this:

A bronze maiden am I, placed on Midas' tomb,
As long as water flows and trees grow tall,
Remaining here on his much lamented grave,
I tell all who pass that Midas is buried here.

I expect you notice that it makes no difference whether any line is spoken first or last. 264e

P: You're making fun of our speech, Socrates.

S: Then, so you won't be upset, let's leave that speech alone—though it does seem to me to offer many examples that one could profit from examin-

ing, though certainly not things that anyone should try to imitate. Let's turn instead to the other speeches. I think there was something in them that should be investigated by those interested in examining speeches.

P: What're you referring to?

265a

S: The two were opposites in a way. One said that one ought to please the one who loves, the other the one who doesn't.

P: And quite manfully.

S: I thought you were going to state the truth and say "madly"—which is just what I was going to ask about. We said that love is a sort of madness, didn't we?

P: Yes.

S: And that there are two forms of madness, one caused by human sickness and the other by a divine disruption of customary behavior.

P: Certainly.

265b

S: We distinguished four parts of the divine type, associated with four gods: Prophetic madness was ascribed to the inspiration of Apollo, the madness connected with the mysteries to Dionysus, poetic madness in turn to the Muses, and the fourth, the erotic madness that we said is the best, to Aphrodite and Love. We described erotic passion in, I don't know, a sort of figurative manner, perhaps touching on something of the truth but also probably being led astray at other points. The mixture was a not altogether unconvincing speech, and we playfully sang, in properly worshipful tones, a sort of mythical hymn to Love, who is my master and yours too, Phaedrus, and the guardian of beautiful boys.

265c

P: For my part, it was certainly not unpleasant to listen to.

S: Let's take up the question now of how the speech managed to shift from censure to praise.

P: What do you mean?

S: It appears to me that while in other respects it was playfully done, among those remarks two principles were mentioned by chance, and if someone could grasp their essence in an artful manner, it wouldn't be insignificant.

265d

P: What principles?

S: To bring together things that are scattered about and see them in terms of a single form, so that by defining it one can always make clear what one intends to expound. Just so, in the case of what was offered earlier as a definition of love, whether the definition was stated well or poorly, it did enable the speech to proceed in a manner that was at any rate clear and self-consistent.

P: What's the other principle you refer to, Socrates?

S: Being able to dissect a thing in accordance with its forms, following the natural joints and not trying to hack it apart like an incompetent butcher. Just so, the two earlier speeches both took the lack of good sense in one's thinking as a single form. Then, just as the body, which is one thing, is naturally divided into pairs, with both parts of each pair called by the same names and labelled left and right, so also, the two speeches assumed that derangement is by its nature a single form in us, but divisible into two parts. One speech cut off the left-hand part and continued dividing this, not quitting until it found among the parts what we are calling a sort of left-hand love, which it very justly censured. The other speech led us into the sections of the right-hand part of madness, and finding a kind of love which has the same name as the other but is divine, it held it up and praised it as the cause of our greatest goods.

P: What you say is very true.

S: I, myself, Phaedrus, am a lover of these dividings and collectings as what enable me to speak and to think, and when I believe that someone else is able to see the natural unity and plurality of things, I follow him, "walking behind him in his footsteps as in those of a god."⁹⁰ Moreover, up to now, I've called those who're able to do this dialecticians,⁹¹ though whether I address them correctly or not only a god knows. However, tell me what those who have learned from you and Lysias now call them. Is this that art of making speeches by means of which Thrasyarchus and others have become skilled speakers themselves and make others such as well, if the latter are willing to bring them offerings fit for kings?

P: They may act like kingly men, but they lack knowledge of what you're talking about. You seem to me to name this form of art correctly when you call it dialectical, but I believe the rhetorical kind is still eluding us.

S: What're you saying? Could there be any fine and noble thing that is undertaken in an artful manner in separation from these principles? If so, you and I certainly shouldn't despise it, but should state what the remaining part of the rhetorical art is.

P: Well, Socrates, a great many things are written in the books on the art of making speeches.

S: You do well to remind me. First, I believe, an introduction must be given at the beginning of the speech. These are the things you mean, aren't they, the fine points of the art?

P: Yes.

S: Second is a statement of the facts with any direct evidence to support it, third is indirect evidence, fourth is what seems probable, and I believe confirmation and supplementary confirmation are spoken of by that outstanding master-artist in words, the man from Byzantium.

P: Are you speaking of the good Theodorus?⁹²

S: Who else? He also speaks of a refutation and supplementary refutation that must be made in both prosecution and defense. But shouldn't we bring the illustrious Evenus of Paros⁹³ into our circle? He first invented insinuation and indirect praises, and some say he also states indirect censures in verse as an aid to memory—a wise man. Shall we let Tisias⁹⁴ and Gorgias rest in peace, who say that what's probable is more important than what's true, who make trivial matters seem major and major matters trivial through the power of speech and present what's new as old and vice versa, and who discovered how to make speeches of concise or unlimited length on any and every subject? Prodicus⁹⁵ once laughed when he heard this latter point from me, and said that he alone had discovered what the art requires of speeches: What is required is that they be neither long nor short, but of the proper length.

P: Ah, most clever Prodicus!

S: Shouldn't we mention Hippias? I believe the visitor from Elis would agree with Prodicus.

P: Why not?

S: What shall we say about the sacred things of Polus⁹⁶ speeches (such as speaking repetitiously and speaking in maxims and speaking with similes) and the terms Licymnius⁹⁷ gave him to facilitate eloquence?

P: Weren't there some such things from Protagoras,⁹⁸ Socrates?

S: In particular, my boy, there were correctness of diction and many other fine things. Yet the mighty Chalcedonian⁹⁹ appears to me to be supreme in the art of making speeches that arouse pity for old age or poverty. He was also fiendishly clever at rousing a crowd to anger and then when they were angry, calming them down again with his incantations, as he said, and he was unbeatable at slandering as well as overcoming slander, regardless of its source. Everyone seems to be in general agreement about the conclusion of speeches, though some call it recapitulation while others give it other names.

P: Do you mean summarizing the points at the end to remind the audience of what's been said?

S: That's what I mean. Do you have anything further to say about the art of making speeches?

P: Only minor points not worth mentioning.

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S: Let's leave aside minor matters, and hold these other points up to a stronger light to see how and where the art functions.

P: It's a very powerful art, Socrates, especially in large meetings.

S: So it is, but, you divine¹⁰⁰ fellow, look and see whether you think, as I do, that their warp has gaps in it.

P: Just point them out.

S: Well, tell me, if someone came to your associate Eryximachus or his father Acumenus¹⁰¹ and said, "I know how to apply certain sorts of things to people's bodies so as to induce warmth or coolness if I want to, and if I choose I can make them vomit or make their bowels move, and a great many other such things; and because I know these things I'm a competent physician and can make a physician out of anyone else to whom I transmit knowledge of these things." What do you think they'd say if they heard that?

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P: What else but to ask whether he also knew to whom one should do these things and when, and to what extent?

S: What if he then said, "Not at all; rather, I expect the person who has learned from me to be able to work out what you refer to by himself"?

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P: I think they'd say the fellow was mad, that after reading something in a book or chancing upon some medications he supposes himself to have become a physician, when he knows nothing of the art.

S: What if someone met Sophocles or Euripides and said that he knew how to compose long orations about a trivial matter and very short orations about an important matter, that he could compose those that would arouse pity, when he wanted to, or, on the other hand, frightening and threatening ones, and many other such, and that he believed that by teaching these things he gave people the ability to compose tragedies?

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P: I expect they too would laugh at anyone, Socrates, who thought a tragedy was anything other than the proper arrangement of those elements so that they harmonize with one another and the whole.

S: Yet I don't think they would berate him in a rough, rude manner. They would act like the musician who meets a man who thinks he understands harmony because he knows how to produce the lowest and highest notes on the lyre. He wouldn't speak to him in a savage manner, saying, "You worthless wretch, you make me sick!" As a devotee of the Muses, he would speak more gently, saying, "You excellent fellow, whoever intends to understand harmony must necessarily know that, but a person who has what you've

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acquired may not understand harmony in the least. What you know must be learned as a prerequisite for understanding harmony, but is not harmony itself."

P: Absolutely right.

S: So Sophocles would say that the person showing off to them knew the prerequisites for tragedy but not tragedy itself, and Acumenus would say that the man in his case knew the prerequisites for medicine but not medicine itself. 269a

P: Most certainly.

S: What do you think about honey-tongued Adrastus, or even Pericles?¹⁰² What if they heard about these splendid artistic devices we were just referring to, conciseness of speech and speaking with similes and the many other things we were considering and said we were going to hold up to the light for examination. Would they, like you and I, make some coarse, rude remark to those who've written about these things and teach them as the art of rhetoric? Or, since they're wiser than we are, would they rebuke us and say, "Phaedrus and Socrates, you mustn't be harsh but forgiving, if certain people who lack knowledge of dialectic¹⁰³ are unable to give a definition of what rhetoric is and because of being in this condition think they have discovered rhetoric when what they have learned are the necessary prerequisites to the art. You must be forgiving if such people believe that when they teach these things to others they've provided a complete course in rhetoric and that since there's nothing to the task of using these devices in a persuasive manner and putting the whole thing together, their students must take care of that by themselves in their speeches." 269b 269c

P: Of course, Socrates. It does seem likely that it's something like this that makes up the art these men teach and write about as rhetoric. What you said seems true to me. But how and where can one acquire the art that belongs to the real orator and to the person who is able to persuade? 269d

S: Acquiring the ability to become a perfect competitor, Phaedrus, is probably, and perhaps necessarily, in this as it is in everything else. If you are naturally a rhetorical person, you'll be a famous orator, provided you add on knowledge and practice. Should you lack any of these, in that respect you'll be imperfect. As far as the art itself is concerned, it seems apparent to me that the way to go is not the road travelled by Lysias and Thrasymachus.

P: What is the way, then?

S: It's really not surprising, you excellent fellow, that Pericles became the most perfect of all in rhetoric. 269e

P: Why?

S: All the great arts require facility at conversation and lofty speculation about nature; these seem to be the sources of high-mindedness and the ability to be completely effective in every situation. That's what Pericles added to his natural talent. I believe he spent some time with Anaxagoras,¹⁰⁴ who was that sort of person, and by steeping himself in lofty speculation grasped the nature of intelligence and the lack of it (topics about which Anaxagoras regularly made long speeches) and drew from that what he could usefully apply to the art of making speeches. 270a

P: What do you mean by that?

S: That the method of the medical art is the same as that of the rhetorical art. 270b

P: How so?

S: In both cases the nature of something must be analyzed, in the one that of the body and in the other that of the soul, if you intend to proceed in an artful manner and not merely by means of practice and experience in providing in the one health and strength by prescribing medication and diet and in implanting in the other the conviction and excellence you want by means of speeches and refined rules of conduct.

P: That seems quite likely, Socrates.

S: Then, do you think it's possible to formulate a worthwhile analysis of the nature of a particular soul without an understanding of the nature of the soul in a general sense? 270c

P: If we are to follow Hippocrates the Asclepiad,¹⁰⁵ one can't make a worthwhile analysis of a particular body, either, without taking that approach.

S: He gives good advice, my friend, yet even in the presence of Hippocrates we must review the analysis to see whether it's cogent.

P: I agree.

S: Then, consider how Hippocrates and the true account speak about the nature of something. Isn't this the way we should think about the nature of anything whatsoever? First, determine whether that, in regard to which we desire to be artful ourselves and to be able to make others such, is simple or complex. Then, if it's simple, inquire as to what natural capacities it has, what it can do to what, and in what ways it can be affected and by what. If it has more than one form, enumerate these and consider each of them as in the case where there was a single form: on the one hand, what it is its nature to do by itself and on the other hand in what ways it can be affected and by what. 270d

P: That seems likely, Socrates.

S: At any rate, an approach that lacked these steps would seem like the stumbling of a blind man. Surely we mustn't compare the person who pursues any subject whatsoever in an artful manner to someone who's blind or deaf. On the contrary, it's obvious that anyone who teaches someone about speeches in an artful manner will show precisely what the essential nature of that thing is toward which one will direct one's speeches, and that, I assume, is the soul. 270e

P: Of course.

S: Then, every effort is aimed at that, for it's in the soul that one tries to produce conviction. Isn't that so? 271a

P: Yes.

S: It's obvious, then, that both Thrasymachus and anyone else who teaches the art of rhetoric seriously will first write very accurately about the soul and will make us see whether it's simple and uniform in nature or complex like the form of the body. That's what we mean by showing what its nature is.

P: Certainly.

S: Secondly, he'll describe what it is its nature to do with what, or to have done to it by what.

P: Of course.

S: Thirdly, he'll classify the various kinds of speeches and kinds of soul, fitting each kind of one to a kind of the other, and he'll also classify the ways in which souls can be affected, giving explanations of every case and showing by what sort of speeches one soul will inevitably be persuaded and another not. 271b

P: At any rate, that would be the best way, I think.

S: So it is, my friend. There will never be any other way than this of speaking or writing in an artful manner in a demonstration or an actual oration, neither on this topic nor on any other. However, current writers about the arts of making speeches to whom you've listened are crafty and keep their thorough knowledge of the soul hidden. So, until they speak and write in this way, we won't believe that they write in an artful manner. 271c

P: What way is that?

S: It's not easy to provide the actual words, but I'm willing to state the manner in which one must write if one intends to be as artful as possible.

P: Speak then.

S: Since the power of speech consists in the leading of souls, the person who intends to be an orator must know what kinds of souls there are. Now, there are a certain number of them, of various types, so that some people are of one sort and others of another. Moreover, after these have been distinguished in this way, there are a certain number of kinds of speeches, and each speech is a particular type. Thus, people of a certain sort are easily persuaded by speeches of a particular type to do certain sorts of things for a certain reason, while people of a different sort will not be persuaded for other reasons. After one has an adequate understanding of these matters, one must be able to perceive and distinguish these types accurately when one observes them actually occurring in practice; otherwise, one won't yet have any advantage from what one heard when one was attending lectures before. When one is qualified to say which sort of person will be persuaded by which sorts of speeches and one has the ability to determine for oneself regarding a person one encounters that this is the person and the very nature that the lectures before were about, now actually present, to whom one must apply speeches of this particular sort in this manner in order to persuade him of these kinds of things, when one has acquired all this, understands when one should speak and when one should keep silent, and can distinguish when it is appropriate and when inappropriate to use concise speech, speech that arouses pity, exaggeration, and each of the other kinds of speeches one has learned about, then and not until then, will the art be properly and completely mastered. If someone falls short in these matters in his speaking, teaching, or writing, while he may claim to speak in an artful manner, the one who doesn't believe him is in the stronger position. "Well now," the writer on this topic will perhaps say, "does this seem correct, Phaedrus and Socrates, or should we describe the art of making speeches in some other way?"

P: It's impossible to accept any other account, Socrates, yet it seems no small task.

S: What you say is true. That's why all our statements must be examined backwards and forwards to see whether there's a quicker and easier way along the road to this art so that one won't waste effort on a long and rough road when there's a short and smooth one. If you've heard anything that would be helpful from Lysias or anyone else, try to remember and say what it was.

P: I could try, but at the moment I've nothing like that to offer.

S: Then, would you like for me to recount a speech I've heard from some of those concerned with these matters?

P: Of course.

S: It's said, Phaedrus, that it's legitimate to speak on behalf of the wolf.¹⁰⁶

P: Then, do so.

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S: Well, then, they say there's no need to be so pompous or to make a long uphill struggle of coming to grips with these matters. As we said at the beginning of this discussion, the person who intends to be competent at rhetoric has no need at all to be concerned about the truth regarding which actions are just or good or which human beings are such by nature or by training. In court, no one cares at all about the truth of these matters, but only about what's persuasive, and that is what is probable. It's to this that the person who intends to speak artfully must attend. Sometimes one mustn't tell what was actually done, if what was done isn't probable; instead one should say what is probable, in both prosecution and defense. Every time one speaks, one must pursue the probable, often bidding truth farewell. When this happens throughout one's speech, it supplies the entire art. 272e 273a

P: Socrates, you've stated just what those who claim to be artful in making speeches say. I remember that we touched briefly on this sort of thing earlier, and it seems to be a point of great importance to those concerned with these matters.

S: Well, you've thumbed through Tisias carefully; let's allow Tisias to speak about this also. Does he say that the probable is nothing more than what seems to most people to be the case? 273b

P: What else could he say?

S: Apparently, after he discovered that wise and artful point, he wrote that if someone who is weak but brave beats up a strong coward and steals his cloak or something and is brought to trial for it, then neither of them ought to tell the truth. The coward should deny that the brave man was acting alone when he beat him up, and the other should contend that there were only the two of them, making effective use of the claim, "How could someone like me assault someone like him?" The coward, of course, won't mention his cowardice, but will quickly try to produce another lie, which will supply his opponent with a basis for further refutation. And in other cases speaking artfully will be similar, won't it, Phaedrus? 273c

P: Of course.

S: My, what a cleverly hidden art he has discovered—Tisias or whoever it may happen to be and whatever he enjoys being named after.¹⁰⁷ But my friend, should we or shouldn't we say to him...

P: What?

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S: This: "Tisias, for some time now before you came along, we've been saying that this probability comes about for the general public because of a

similarity to the truth, and we just explained how the person who's seen the truth always knows best how to find these similarities. If you have anything other than that to say about the art of making speeches, we'll listen, but if not, we'll accept what we just went over, namely, that unless a person can distinguish the natures of those who are listening and can divide the things that exist in accordance with their forms and comprehend each individual thing in terms of a single form, one will never be as artful in one's speeches as a person can be. One will not acquire this ability without a great deal of effort, which the sensible person ought not to expend for the sake of speaking and acting before human beings, but so as to be able both to say what's pleasing to the gods and to do everything in a manner that pleases them to the best of one's ability. Those who're wiser than we, Tisias, say that the intelligent person mustn't practice doing what will please one's fellow slaves, except coincidentally, but rather what will please one's good and noble masters. So don't be surprised if the way round is long; one must make the circuit for the sake of great purposes, not for the sort you have in mind. Yet these latter purposes also, if someone is interested in them, will be achieved best by this means, as our discussion shows."

P: That seems very good advice to me, Socrates, if only one could follow it.

S: It's a noble thing to attempt noble deeds and then suffer the consequences.

P: Certainly.

S: Then, let that be enough about the art and the lack of art in making speeches.

P: Of course.

S: But the question remains, doesn't it, as to what's appropriate and inappropriate regarding writing, that is, when it's done properly and when improperly?

P: Yes.

S: Then, do you know how best to please the god¹⁰⁸ in connection with speeches, whether making them or discussing them?

P: Not at all. Do you?

S: I can tell you what I have heard from our predecessors, but only they themselves know the truth. If we could discover that ourselves, would mere human opinions continue to concern us?

P: A ridiculous question. But tell what you say you've heard.

S: Well, then, I heard that at Naucratis in Egypt there lived one of the ancient gods of that region, the one whose sacred bird they called Ibis. The name of the divine being himself is Theuth.¹⁰⁹ He was the first to invent mathematics, geometry, and astronomy, as well as backgammon and dice, and, moreover, written letters.¹¹⁰ At that time Thamus was the king of all of Egypt around the great city of the upper region that the Greeks call Egyptian Thebes. They call the god Ammon. Theuth came to Thamus and demonstrated his arts, saying that they ought to be passed on to the rest of the Egyptians. Thamus asked about the usefulness of each and, as Theuth went through them, condemned some and praised others, depending on whether Theuth's claims seemed well-taken or not. It's said that Thamus presented many points both for and against each art, which would take a long speech to report, but when it came to letters, Theuth said, "This branch of learning, your majesty, will make the Egyptians wiser and improve their memories, for I've discovered a magic potion¹¹¹ for memory and wisdom." But Thamus replied, "Most artful Theuth, while one person is able to create the products of art, another is able to judge what harm or benefit they hold for those who intend to use them. Now you, the father of letters, as a result of your affection for them, are stating just the opposite of what their effect will be. If people learn them it will make their souls forgetful through lack of exercising their memory. They'll put their trust in the external marks of writing instead of using their own internal capacity for remembering on their own. You've discovered a magic potion not for memory, but for reminding, and you offer your pupils apparent, not true, wisdom. After they have heard many things from you, but without instruction, they will seem to be very knowledgeable when they are for the most part ignorant, and they will be hard to get along with, since they will have only the appearance of wisdom instead of being really wise."

P: Socrates, you easily make up stories about the Egyptians or anyone else you want to.

S: My friend, those at the temple of Zeus at Dodona said that the first prophetic speeches were those of an oak tree. Back then, since they weren't wise the way you young people are today, people were content in their simplicity to listen to an oak tree or a rock, if it spoke the truth. For you, perhaps it makes a difference who the speaker is and where he comes from. You don't just consider whether what's said is so or not.

P: You rightly rebuke me. I think the situation regarding letters is just as the Theban says.

S: So, the person who thinks he is leaving behind an art in written form, and in turn the person who receives it, on the assumption that anything clear and reliable will be available from something in written form, would be exceedingly simple-minded as well as really ignorant of the prophecy of

Ammon, if he thinks that written works are anything more than reminders for the person who knows the subject of the written material. 275d

P: Quite right.

S: In a way, Phaedrus, writing has a strange character, which is similar to that of painting, actually. Painting's creations stand there as though they were alive, but if you ask them anything, they maintain a quite solemn silence. Speeches are the same way. You might expect them to speak like intelligent beings, but if you question them with the intention of learning something about what they're saying, they always just continue saying the same thing. Every speech, once it's in writing, is bandied about everywhere equally among those who understand and those who've no business having it. It doesn't know to whom it ought to speak and to whom not. When it's ill-treated and unfairly abused, it always needs its father to help it, since it isn't able to help or defend itself by itself. 275e

P: You're quite right about that also.

S: What about this? Can we see another kind of speech that's a legitimate brother of that one and see how it comes into being and how it is from its birth much better and more powerful than that one? 276a

P: What kind of speech is this, and how do you mean it comes into being?

S: That which is written along with knowledge in the soul of the learner, that's able to defend itself by itself and knows to whom it ought to speak and before whom it ought to keep silent.

P: You mean the living and ensouled¹¹² speech of the person who knows, of which a written speech may justly be called a kind of image.

S: Precisely. Now, tell me this. Would a sensible farmer who had some seeds he cared about and who wanted to produce a crop plant them with serious intent in the heat of summer in gardens for Adonis¹¹³ and enjoy seeing them bloom beautifully in eight days? If he did such things at all, wouldn't he do them for the sake of amusement and at festivals? In those cases where he was serious, wouldn't he use the farmer's art and plant in suitable ground and prefer having what he has sown reach maturity in the eighth month? 276b

P: Probably, Socrates, as you say, he'd do the one seriously and the other otherwise. 276c

S: Shall we say that the person who has a knowledge of what's just, beautiful, and good is less sensible about his seeds than the farmer?

P: Not in the least.

S: Then, when he's serious he won't write them in ink, using a pen to sow speeches that are unable to defend themselves in discussion and unable to teach the truth effectively.

P: That's not likely.

S: No, it isn't. He'll sow his gardens of letters for amusement, it seems, and will write, when he does write, to store up reminders for himself, and for all who follow the same track, against the forgetfulness that may come with old age, and he'll enjoy watching their tender shoots grow. While others resort to other kinds of play, refreshing themselves with drinking parties and whatever is related to these, this person, it seems, instead of indulging in these kinds of play, will engage in those I'm speaking of. 276d

P: You refer to a very noble kind of play, Socrates, in contrast to a worthless kind, that of the person who is able to play with speeches, telling tales about justice and the other things you mention.¹¹⁴ 276e

S: So it is, Phaedrus my friend, but far more noble, I think, is the serious treatment of these subjects when someone uses the dialectical art and, selecting an appropriate soul, plants and sows in it speeches that are accompanied by knowledge, speeches that can defend both themselves and the one who planted them and that are not barren but contain a seed from which others grow up in other abodes, so that this process is rendered eternal and immortal.¹¹⁵ Such speeches make the person who possesses them as happy as a human being can be. 277a

P: What you speak of is nobler by far.

S: Now that we've agreed about these matters, Phaedrus, we can decide about those others.

P: What are they?

S: We've gotten to this point because we wanted to know about the following: what we were going to make of the criticism of Lysias as a writer of speeches, and, with regard to speeches themselves, which were written in an artful manner and which not. It seems to me that what is artful and what is not has been made abundantly clear. 277b

P: I thought so, but remind me again how it went.

S: Until one knows the truth about each of the topics one speaks or writes about and is able to define each in its own terms; and until after defining them, one knows how to cut them up again in accordance with their forms until one reaches what's indivisible; and until one comes to an understanding of the nature of the soul in the same way, discovering the form that fits each nature, and arranges and organizes one's speech accordingly, offering to a complex soul complex speeches that cover all the musical modes and simple 277c

speeches to a simple soul; only then will one be able, insofar as it's in accord with its nature, to deal with the race of speeches in an artful manner, either in connection with teaching or in connection with persuading—as the entire preceding discussion has reminded us.

P: Certainly, that is just about how it appeared to us.

S: Then, what about the question as to whether it's a noble or shameful thing to make and write speeches and under what circumstances doing so can justly be made a basis for criticism or not? Didn't what was said a little while ago make clear... 277d

P: What?

S: That if Lysias or anyone else, whether for private use or in public when writing something political as a legislator, ever wrote or shall write anything in the belief that it would possess great clarity and permanence, then such action would make the writer subject to criticism, whether or not anyone says so. Being ignorant, when awake as well as when asleep, of what's just and unjust and of what's good and bad truly cannot escape being subjected to criticism, even if the entire populace praises it. 277e

P: So it cannot.

S: Well, then, Phaedrus, the sort of person whom it is likely that you and I would pray that we both become is the person who believes that there's necessarily a lot that's playful in a written speech on any topic, and that no speech whether in verse or in prose has ever been written that is worthy of much serious consideration, nor any recited in the rhapsodes' manner, that is, for the sake of persuasion without questioning or instruction. He will be the sort of person who believes on the contrary that the best of them in fact have been reminders for those who know, and who believes that the only speeches that are clear, complete, and worthy of serious consideration are those about what's just and beautiful and good that are taught and spoken for the sake of learning and actually written in the soul. He will be the person who believes that his speeches of this sort ought to be spoken of as his legitimate sons, including primarily the one inside himself, if any can be found there, but also any descendants and brothers of that one that have developed along with it in a worthy manner in the souls of others, and he will bid farewell to other sorts of speeches. 278a

P: What you're saying is certainly what I myself wish and pray.

S: Then, we've amused ourselves enough with these issues about making speeches. You go and tell Lysias that we two went down to the spring of the Nymphs and the shrine of the Muses and listened to speeches that commanded us to say the following to Lysias and to anyone else who composes 278c

speeches, and also to Homer and anyone else who's composed poetry, whether without musical accompaniment or to be sung, and thirdly to Solon and whoever else has written political statements that he calls laws. They commanded us to say that if one has composed these things with knowledge of what the truth is, can defend them by talking about what one has written, and by one's own speaking is able to show the inferiority of what's been written, then such a person ought not to be referred to as having a title connected with these latter things, but rather a title connected with those things one is serious about. 278d

P: What titles would you give them, then?

S: To call them "wise" seems excessive to me, Phaedrus, that's appropriate only for a god, but to call them a "friend of wisdom"¹¹⁶ or something of that sort would be both more fitting for them and more harmonious.

P: And not at all inappropriate.

S: On the other hand, the person who has nothing more valuable than what he's composed or written, who spends a lot of time changing his works this way and that, pasting them together and pulling them apart, him, perhaps, you will justly call a poet or a writer of speeches or laws? 278e

P: Of course.

S: Then, tell that to your associate.

P: But what about you? What're you going to do? Isn't it the case that your associate ought not to be neglected?

S: Who's that?

P: The handsome Isocrates.¹¹⁷ What message will you take to him, Socrates? What shall we say he is?

S: Isocrates is still young, Phaedrus, but I'm willing to say what I prophesy for him. 279a

P: What?

S: What lies in his nature seems to me to be superior to what is in Lysias' speeches, and to be combined with a nobler character. It wouldn't be at all surprising, given the kinds of speeches he's now engaged with, if as he grows older he succeeds in making the speeches of his predecessors look like the work of children. Nor would it be a surprise if that doesn't satisfy him and a more divine impulse leads him on to greater things. By virtue of his nature, my friend, a certain friendship with wisdom is present in the thinking of the man. That's the message I'm taking from the gods here to my darling, Isocrates, and you take the other to your darling, Lysias. 279b

P: It shall be done. But let's go, since the heat's become less severe.

S: Shouldn't we offer a prayer to those here as we depart?

P: Of course.

S: Pan,¹¹⁸ my friend, and the other gods of this place, grant that I may develop inward beauty and that my external possessions be in friendly accord with what is within. May I consider the wise rich, and may I have no more gold than a sensible person can carry and manage. 279c

Do we need more than that, Phaedrus? The prayer's sufficient for me.

P: Let me join in that prayer. Friends' things are held in common.

S: Let's go.

examines this issue very thoroughly and argues that it is a major motif in the dialogue as a whole ("The Tragic and Comic Poet of the *Symposium*," in *Essays in Ancient Greek Philosophy*, vol. 2, edited by John P. Anton and Anthony Preus [Albany: State University of New York Press, 1983], 186–202).

CHAPTER 4. THE PHAEDRUS

1. The term translated as "love" throughout the dialogue is ἔρως (*erōs*). See the discussion of the term in the general introduction.

2. Opposing views about the date of composition and discussions of the internal and external evidence can be found in R. Hackforth, *Plato's Phaedrus* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1972), 3–7; and C. J. Rowe, *Plato: Phaedrus* (Warminster, England: Aris & Phillips, 1986), 13–14.

3. Phaedrus was actually in exile from Athens between 415 and 404, as a result of his alleged involvement in the infamous destruction of the Herms. Lysias left Athens as a child and did not return until after 411, and Lysias' brother Polemarchus was murdered in 404. Hence, this dialogue could not depict an actual historical conversation, since in the dialogue Lysias is in Athens (227b), Polemarchus is alive (257b), and Phaedrus is not in exile.

4. Hackforth provides a good summary of this controversy; see *Phaedrus*, 16–18.

5. [227a] A famous orator of the time. A number of his speeches are extant.

6. [227a] A well-known physician, the father of Eryximachus who is one of the speakers in the *Symposium*. See 268a ff.

7. [227b] Morychus was a famous bon vivant, and Epicratus was an orator and active in the democratic faction. Both are mentioned in Aristophanes' plays.

8. [227b] Pindar was a major early fifth-century poet in Athens. The quote is from *Isthmians* I.2.

9. [227c] It is tempting to hear in this phrase an echo of Socrates' claim to be an expert in the activities of *erōs* at *Symposium* 177d.

10. [227c] The verb translated as "to gratify" (χαρίζεσθαι, *charizesthai*) is commonly used as a euphemism for giving in to the sexual demands of a lover. The related noun (χάρις, *charis*) I usually translate as "kindness" (see 231a and 233e).

11. [227c] It was common practice for professional orators to construct display speeches on paradoxical themes to demonstrate their skills. A popular theme for such use was a defense of Helen. It seems likely that Lysias' speech is this sort of thing.

12. [227d] A distance of several miles.

13. [227d] Another physician, also mentioned in *Protagoras* 316d.

14. [228b] This oath apparently refers to an Egyptian deity; see *Gorgias* 482b.

15. [228b] The Corybantic rituals were characterized by joyful enthusiasm and associated with possession and madness.

16. [228c] This little speech illustrates the technique of constructing probabilities that Plato later attributes to Tisias (273a ff.).

17. [229a] Though not in the *Symposium* (174a).

18. [229a] A πλάτωνος, *platanos*. The modern scientific name of the genus is *Platanus*. The American species, *occidentalis*, is the familiar sycamore. The species that exists in Greece is *orientalis* and is usually called the plane-tree. The Greek name means "broad," probably referring to the shape of the leaves. They were present in the Agora. The wood of the *platanos* is mentioned at *Laws* 705c as useful for the interior of boats.

19. [229b] The story is that Oreithuia was the daughter of Erechtheus, one of the legendary kings of Athens. Boreas, the north wind, fell in love with her but was rejected by her father. Boreas then abducted her, and she later bore him two sons. This myth raises the issue of the connection between love and irrational behavior, an important theme in Socrates' second speech. The "wise," whom Socrates refers to below, see in this tale only an accident involving the death of a child. Note that Socrates does not reject this story as untrue. The mythical form of λόγος (*logos*) plays an important role in the *Phaedrus*. (The term μῦθος (*mythos*), from which the English word 'myth' is derived, is translated as "tale.")

20. [229c] Agra was one of the administrative districts or demes of Attica.

21. [229c] The north wind. The Greek word βορέας (*boreas*) refers to the north wind. The Greeks personify many phenomena, using the names of the phenomena as proper names.

22. [229c] "Odd" here and elsewhere translates ἄτοπος (*atopos*) that is, "out of place," a metaphor connected with the situation in the dialogue.

23. [229c] The name of Oreithuia's playmate usually refers to the use of potions for poisoning or witchcraft.

24. [229c] The phrase translated as "a puff of wind" could also be read as "a breath of Boreas."

25. [229d] The Areopagus is the hill in the center of Athens on which the Parthenon and other public buildings are located.

26. [229e] A Centaur is half man and half horse. A Chimaera has a goat's body with a lion's head and a serpent's tail. A Gorgon has snakes for hair; the most famous one is Medusa. A Pegasus is a horse with wings.

27. [229e] Delphi is a center for the worship of Apollo. There was a famous oracle there.

28. [230a] Typhon (Τυφῶν, *Typhōn*) means “vanity” or “arrogance.” The root metaphor is smoke, and the idea seems to be that a vain person’s true self is obscured by a smoke-screen. The mythical character called Typhon is a hundred-headed monster who challenged the gods but was killed by Zeus; see Hesiod, *Theogony* 820ff. “Agitated” translates a verb based on *typhōn*, ἐπιτυφέσθαι (*epituphesthai*), which means “to be inflamed” and is used by Aristophanes to mean “consumed by lust.”

29. [230b] The consort of Zeus.

30. [230b] An ἄγνος (*agnos*). The modern scientific name is *Vitex agnus-castus*. The Greek name refers to the flexible nature of the young shoots. Though often described as willowlike, the chaste tree, as it is commonly called, is not a member of *Salix*, the willow genus. It is a shrubby tree with leaves that are palmately compound, composed of five to seven lanceolate leaflets, so that each leaflet does resemble a willow leaf. The flowers are blue, in showy, upright clusters. Both leaves and flowers have a strong, pungent odor. In ancient Greece it was considered an anti-aphrodisiac, which may be connected with the fact that its name is similar to ἄγνός (*hagnos*), which means “chaste,” “pure,” or “holy.” This latter term occurs in the *Phaedrus* at 254b, where I translate it as “sacred.”

31. [230c] Achelous is the primary river god.

32. [230d] “Prescription” translates φάρμακον (*pharmakon*), which means medicine, remedy, or potion, and may be used for good or ill. This is a striking metaphor to use for λόγος, *logos*. The term is also used at 274e and 275a, where I translate it as “magic potion.”

33. [232a] A more literal translation in place of this adverb would be “out of friendship with fame and honor.”

34. [234a] Literally, this phrase is “will befriend fame and honor in front of everyone.”

35. [234d] “Unearthly” translates δαιμόνιον, *daimonion*; see note on 242c.

36. [234d] The feasts and rites associated with the god Bacchus (also called Dionysus) are particularly extravagant and frenzied and are associated with possession and madness.

37. [235c] Sappho and Anacreon are well-known sixth-century poets, particularly famous for their poems about love.

38. [236b] The offering referred to is probably a golden statue of Zeus.

39. [236b] “Darling” translates παιδικά (*paidika*), the standard term for the youthful beloved in a love affair.

40. [236d] A phrase from the poet Pindar. Plato also uses this quotation at *Meno* 76d.

41. [237a] Plato here plays on the name Ligurian and the word λιγύς (*ligus*), which means “clear voiced.”

42. [237e] This is an example of the sort of usage of *logos* that is traditionally translated as "reason" or "rational" rather than as "speech." *Logos* can be translated as "speech" here if we think of speech as a gathering of things so as to reveal their nature. Note that *logos* here is being given a certain precedence in the process of human understanding. This usage sheds important light on the relation between *logos* and τὰ ὄντα (*ta onta*), "the things that are," "reality." In the next sentence in the text, the phrase "in a manner contrary to reason" translates the privative adverbial form of *logos*.

43. [238a] I have not found a good translation for the Greek term ὕβρις, *hubris*, in this context. It generally refers to what is outrageous, what violates traditional practice, good sense, or the law. The term "hubris" as used in English has the somewhat different, though related, sense of "arrogance" or "excessive self-confidence." Some choices by other translators are "wantonness" (Hackforth) and "excess" (Rowe). The adjectival form of this term is translated as "hubristic" at 252b, 254c and 254e, and should be understood in the Greek sense. In the *Symposium* the term is translated as "outrageous."

44. [238c] Socrates' conclusion includes an appeal to etymological connections. The "strength" associated here with *erōs* is ῥῶμη (*rhōmē*). The etymological play also involves the phrase "is powerfully strengthened," which is ἐρρωμένως ῥωσθεῖσα (*errōmenōs rhōstheisa*), two forms of the verb ῥώννυμι (*rhōnnumi*), which like *rhōmē* and *erōs* involves the radical ῥω (*rō*).

45. [238d] Dithyrambic is a metrical style associated with Bacchus (Dionysus) and usually characterized by exaggerated, affected language. Socrates is probably referring to the flamboyant etymology of his final paragraph. Cf. Plato's *Cratylus* 409c.

46. [241b] The reference is to a game played with oyster shells in which the players formed opposing teams and each team ran away or pursued according to which side of a tossed shell fell uppermost.

47. [241e] The epic style in poetry is that of Homer and was rather archaic by Socrates' day. Perhaps he is referring to the bold metaphor in his final line.

48. [242a] Socrates here calls his first *logos* a *mythos*, as he does at 237a.

49. [242a] This phrase apparently refers to the fact that the sun appears to stand still at noon. Phaedrus makes a play on its literal meaning.

50. [242a] "Superhuman" translates δαιμόνιον, *daimonion*; see note on 242c.

51. [242b] Simmias is a major character in the *Phaedo*.

52. [242c] Socrates refers to this phenomenon in *Apology* 31c–d: "Something divine and daimonic comes to me.... This began in my childhood. A certain voice comes, which, whenever it comes, always turns me away from what I was about to do, but it never gives me positive direction." See also *Apology* 40a. The term 'daimonic' (δαιμόνιον, *daimonion*) has special connotations in the *Symposium* because of Diotima's identification of Love as a daimon. Socrates does not refer to his famous sign in

the *Symposium*, and there is no explicit reference to the notion of the daimon as a special intermediary figure in the *Phaedrus* or the *Apology*. In this context the term is probably to be taken as a loose synonym for “divine” (θεῖον, *theion*).

53. [242c] A sixth-century poet.

54. [242d] Aphrodite is the goddess of sexual passion. Plato gives a different account of the genealogy and status of Love (*Erōs*) in Socrates’ report of Diotima’s views in the *Symposium*. There Love is conceived on the day of Aphrodite’s birth, rather than being her son, and is a daimon, rather than a god (*Symposium* 202d–203c).

55. [243a] A seventh-century poet. Plato also refers to this incident at *Republic* 586c.

56. [244a] Some readers find this series of names to be significant. For example, V. Tejera writes: “The reader becomes conscious of the connotations of the name Stesichorus, or ‘choral leader,’ and of the beautiful meaning of the name of the beautiful youngster [Phaedrus], the ‘shining one.’ He is the son of the ‘fame seeker’ (Pythocles) from ‘Wreathville’ (Myrrhinous), while the repentant poet is the son of ‘Mr. Finespeak’ (Euphemos) from ‘Longington’ (Himera).” *Plato’s Dialogues One by One* (New York: Irvington Publishers, 1984), 49.

57. [244a] There was a major shrine and oracle for Apollo at Delphi. Dodona was the site of an oak tree that was sacred to Zeus. The rustling of its leaves was interpreted for inquirers by the priestesses.

58. [244b] A legendary prophetess located in Asia Minor.

59. [245c] Aristotle attributes the claim that what is immortal is always changing to the fifth century Pythagorean thinker Alcmaeon of Crotona (*De Anima* 405a30).

60. [245c] The word translated as “origin” in this passage, ἀρχή (*archē*), is frequently translated as “first principle.” The basic notion is what serves as a source, beginning, or point of origin.

61. [245d] This sentence has baffled readers since ancient times. Some scholars change the text to read: “For if an origin comes into being from something, it would not still be an origin.” Perhaps the claim is that if origins come into being, they must come from nonorigins or from origins. If the latter, they come from themselves, which is to say that they do not come into being at all. If the former, their “origin” is from what is *not* an origin, which is absurd. Therefore, origins do not come into being.

62. [245e] A similar argument is offered at *Phaedo* 72a–d.

63. [245e] A similar view of the definition of “soul” occurs at *Laws* 895e–896a.

64. [246b] All living things have souls, hence there is a question as to why some of them would be called mortal, the soul having been shown to be immortal.

65. [246d] Literally, this phrase reads: “as is friendly to the god.” The reference to “the god” is generic rather than specific, an expression of ordinary piety.

66. [247a] Hestia is the goddess of the hearth. The twelve ruling gods are presumably the traditional gods of Olympus and may also have been associated with the twelve signs of the Zodiac. See *Laws* 828c.

67. [247c] The image is of standing on the outside of a sphere.

68. [248c]Adrasteia is the goddess of that which is inevitable, destiny.

69. [248d] That is, a philosopher, *philosophos*.

70. [249a] Dike is the goddess of justice.

71. [250b] Themis is the goddess of custom or tradition.

72. [252b] The Homericists were special authorities on the works of Homer. Nothing is known of these verses apart from their appearance here. On the question of the sense in which the second line is hubristic, see W. H. Thompson, *The Phaedrus of Plato* (London: Whittaker & Co., 1868), 66–67: “In calling the second line [hubristic] Plato does not refer to any supposed lewd meaning...but simply to the extravagance of the conception and the words in which it is embodied.”

73. [252c] Ares is the god of war and destruction.

74. [253b] Apollo, who speaks through the oracle at Delphi, is connected with both prophecy and the arts of music and poetry.

75. [255c] Because of his beauty, Ganymede was abducted to be the wine-server for Zeus. His father Tros was compensated with a gift of marvellous horses. See *Iliad* XX.232–35; and V.265–67. This reference reminds the reader of the earlier story about Oreithuia (229b–d).

76. [255e] Here and in the next paragraph, the term translated as “kiss” is literally “befriend,” but it seems here to have the limited sense of “kiss” or “caress.”

77. [257b] Polemarchus captures Socrates at the beginning of the *Republic* and that dialogue takes place at his family's home in Piraeus.

78. [257c] That is, his “reputation,” φιλοτιμία (*philotimia*).

79. [257e] Several explanations of this remark have been proposed. A plausible one is that the long bend in the Nile which came to be called Pleasant Bend actually is unpleasant because it makes the journey much longer. Socrates' point, then, is that names may be ironic, and Lysias' critic's words should not be taken at face value.

80. [258c] Lycurgus and Solon are held to be the founders of the Spartan and Athenian constitutions respectively. Darius was one of the great kings of Persia. Lycurgus and Solon are also singled out at *Symposium* 209d.

81. [259a] The songs of the Sirens were so enticing that they lured sailors to their deaths on the rocky outcroppings where they sang.

82. [260a] *Iliad* II.361.

83. [260d] This phrase is literally “the art of speeches,” ἡ τῶν λόγων τέχνη, *hē tōn logōn technē* (τῶν λόγων is the plural of λόγος in the possessive case). To make the phrase less awkward in English, I add “making” on the assumption that it includes both composing and delivering speeches, as well as spontaneous, responsive interchange.

84. [260e] An “art” (τέχνη, *technē*) involves achieving proper results on the basis of knowledge of the relevant principles. It is a craft or science that requires mastery and expertise. To do something in an “artful” manner is not merely to act gracefully or in an aesthetically pleasing manner, but to act in a way that reflects the understanding of one who has mastered a profession.

85. [260e] The significance of the reference to the Spartan is unclear. It may reflect the Spartans’ reputation for blunt, direct speech, or perhaps the unusual word translated as “genuine” (ἔτυμος, *etumos*) is from the Spartan dialect.

86. [261a] Probably a reference to Phaedrus’ role in originating speeches. See 242b and *Symposium* 177d.

87. [261b] Nestor is the eloquent elder statesman of the *Iliad* (see *Iliad* I.249). Odysseus is famous for his cleverness and resourcefulness, and Helen says that no one could compete with him as a speaker (*Iliad* III.223). Palamedes, who is famous for his inventions, is identified at 261d with Zeno of Elea, who is famous for his technique of drawing contradictory conclusions from a single premiss (see *Parmenides* 127d–128a).

88. [261c] Gorgias, Thrasymachus, and Theodorus are all famous orators of the time and appear in other Platonic dialogues.

89. [263d] Pan plays the pan-pipe and is associated with shepherding, having goats’ legs, ears, and horns. He is also especially amorous. In *Cratylus* 408c–d Socrates identifies him with *logos*. Hermes is the god of change and transformation and hence of good, and bad, luck.

90. [266b] An adaptation of *Odyssey* V.193.

91. [266b] The term is διαλεκτικός, *dialektikos*, which is connected with the term *logos* and refers especially to skill in conversation or dialogue.

92. [266e] Aristotle speaks of Theodorus, along with Tisias and Thrasymachus, as an important contributor to the development of oratory (see *On Sophistical Refutations* 183b32).

93. [267a] Evenus is a poet and Sophist, and is also mentioned in *Apology* 20b and *Phaedo* 60d.

94. [267a] Tisias is the teacher of Gorgias.

95. [267b] The Sophists Prodicus and Hippias are characterized in some detail in the *Protagoras*.

96. [267b] Polus is a pupil of Gorgias and plays a major role in Plato’s *Gorgias*.

97. [267c] Aristotle mentions Licymnius as a poet and orator and objects to his superfluous technicalities (see *Rhetoric* 1413b14, 1414b17).

98. [267c] One of the best known of the Sophists. He is a principle character in Plato's *Protagoras*.

99. [267c] Thrasyarchus, whose verbal "might" is displayed in the first book of Plato's *Republic*.

100. [268a] Literally, "daimonic." It seems unlikely that Plato intends a connection here either with Socrates' daimonic voice (242b–c above) or with the special view of the daimon in the *Symposium*. See note on 242c.

101. [268a] Eryximachus is one of the speakers in the *Symposium*. He and his father are well-known physicians.

102. [269a] Adrastus is a mythical king of Argos, contemporary with Theseus; the epithet is from the Spartan poet Tyrtæus. Pericles is the great orator and leader of fifth-century Athens.

103. [269b] Literally, this phrase reads "who do not know how to converse/engage in conversation" (μη̃ ἐπιστάμενοι διαλέγεσθαι, *mē epistamenoi dialegesthai*).

104. [270a] A fifth-century Athenian philosopher.

105. [270c] That is, Hippocrates the physician. The god Asclepius is the founder of the art of medicine.

106. [272c] That is, as we would say, to play the devil's advocate.

107. [273c] Plato may be suggesting that the inventor is really Tisias' teacher, Corax, whose name means "crow."

108. [274b] This is a generic reference, an expression of ordinary piety; Socrates need not have any specific deity in mind.

109. [274c] In the Egyptian pantheon, Theuth parallels the Greek Hermes. The story of his inventing writing is also referred to at *Philebus* 18b.

110. [274d] In traditional Greek mythology Prometheus is the inventor of writing.

111. [274e] That is, a *pharmakon*. See note on 230d.

112. [276a] That is, "animated," to use an equivalent term with a Latin root. This term is redundant here, since being alive involves having a soul. Perhaps the claim that this sort of speech has a soul is intended to imply that it can change itself and the person on whose soul it is inscribed, remembering the earlier definition of soul at 245c–246a.

113. [276b] The reference is to the practice of forcing plants into early bloom in shallow pots at the festival commemorating the untimely death of Adonis.

114. [276e] Plato here and throughout this section of the dialogue seems to be making subtle and ironic reference to his own writing.

115. [277a] This form of immortality is like that which Diotima argues for in the *Symposium*.

116. [278d] That is a “philosopher,” *philosophos*.

117. [278e] Isocrates (436–388 B.C.E.) was a prominent teacher of rhetoric. A number of his written speeches are extant. Since he was an outspoken critic of Plato and Socrates, it seems likely that the praise of him here is ironic.

118. [279b] See note on 263d.

CHAPTER 5. COMMENTARY ON THE PHAEDRUS

1. Nussbaum’s interpretation of the *Phaedrus* is a good example of this approach. She sees it as primarily an expression by Plato of a modification of the view of the role of love in the good life that he has Socrates present in the *Symposium*. In her discussion of the dialogue in *The Fragility of Goodness*, she does not claim to be providing a general interpretation of the dialogue, of course, but it is striking that she has no reservations about treating the discussion of *erōs* as seriously intended by Plato and sees no difficulties in discussing this analysis with little or no reference to the discussion of rhetoric in the latter part of the dialogue. Martha Nussbaum, *The Fragility of Goodness* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986), 200–33.

2. C. J. Rowe, trans., *Plato: Phaedrus* (Warminster, England: Aris & Phillips, 1986), 7.

3. James A. Arieti, *Interpreting Plato: The Dialogues As Drama* (Savage, Md.: Rowman & Littlefield, 1991), chapter on the *Phaedrus*. G. E. L. Owen takes a similarly negative view of the philosophical content of the speeches in the first part of the dialogue, seeing their significance in their exemplification of the method of collection and division (“Plato on the Undepictable,” in E. N. Lee, A. P. D. Mourelatos, and R. M. Rorty, eds., *Phronesis*, supplementary vol. I [*Exegesis and Argument*], 1973, 349–61).

4. Walter Hamilton, trans., *Plato: Phaedrus and the Seventh and Eighth Letters* (Middlessex, England: Penguin Books, 1973), 9–10.

5. A. W. Price, *Love and Friendship in Plato and Aristotle* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1988), 96.

6. R. Hackforth, trans., *Plato's Phaedrus* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1972), 9–10.

7. Rowe, *Plato: Phaedrus*, 9.

8. Charles L. Griswold, Jr., *Self-Knowledge in Plato's Phaedrus* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1986), 2–9 and *passim*.